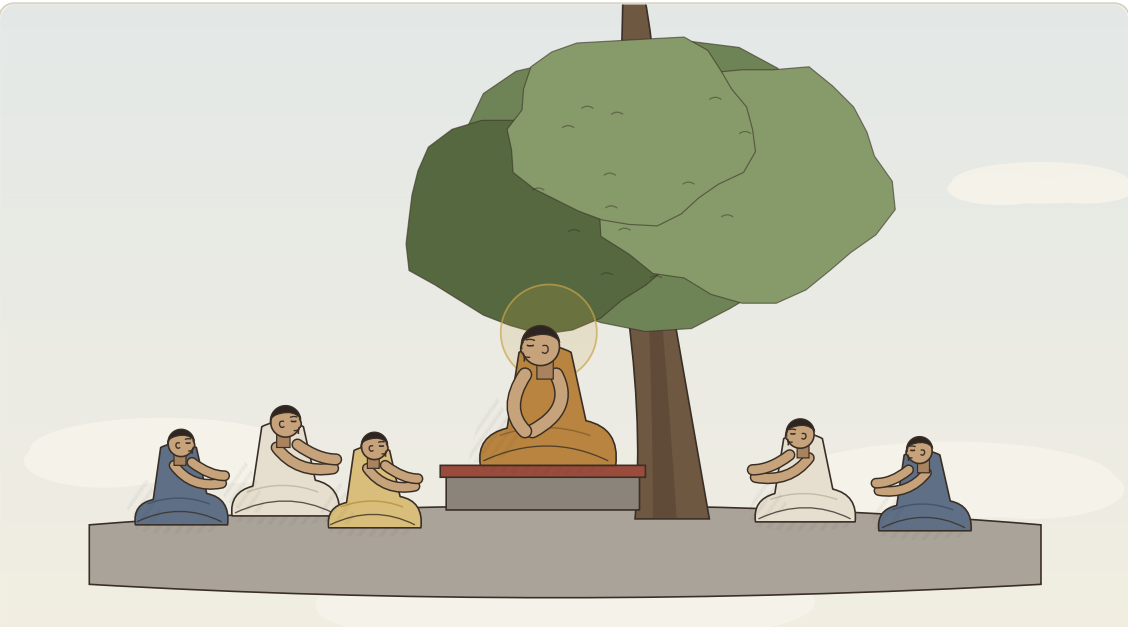
The Abhidhamma for Young Readers

A course in twelve lessons, from *An Introduction to the Abhidhamma* by Jill Jordan, Richard Giles and Nina van Gorkom (Dhamma Study Group, Bangkok, 1980)



"The teachings of the Abhidhamma it is said were first taught to the Buddha's mother and residents of some of the heavenly realms"

Every Pali word is followed by its English in brackets. A quiz follows every two lessons; the answers are at the back.

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How to use this course

This course is about the *Abhidhamma* (the higher teaching), the part of the Buddha's teaching that explains what a person really is: not a lasting someone, but moments of mind and matter arising and falling away, one after another. It has twelve lessons. Each lesson explains one part of the Abhidhamma in plain words, and most lessons also tell a true story from the ancient texts.

Pali words. The Buddha's teaching was written down in a language called Pali. You will meet Pali words all through this course. Every time one appears, its English meaning sits right next to it in brackets, like this: *citta* (consciousness), *rūpa* (matter). You never have to remember a Pali word to understand the page. But if you do remember a few, you will be able to read the ancient texts one day.

Saying the words. A line over a letter makes it long: *ā* sounds like the "a" in "father", *ī* like the "ee" in "see", *ū* like the "oo" in "moon". A dot under a letter (*ṭ*, *ḍ*, *ṇ*) means you curl your tongue back a little. *ñ* sounds like the "ny" in "canyon". *ṃ* sounds like "ng". So *paññā* is said "pan-nyaa" and *saṅkhāra* is said "sang-khaa-ra".

Numbers. The Abhidhamma counts things: 89 kinds of *citta* (consciousness), 52 *cetasika* (mental factors), 28 kinds of *rūpa* (matter), 31 planes of existence. Nobody has to learn the numbers by heart. They are there to show that the Abhidhamma leaves nothing vague.

Hard words. Some English words in this book are hard. The first time a hard word is met in a chapter it has a small number after it, like this: aeons[5]. Its meaning is given at the end of the chapter, under "Hard words in this chapter", and all the hard words are listed together at the back, after the word list. In the web edition, tapping or clicking on the word shows its meaning.

Quizzes. After every two lessons there is a short quiz.

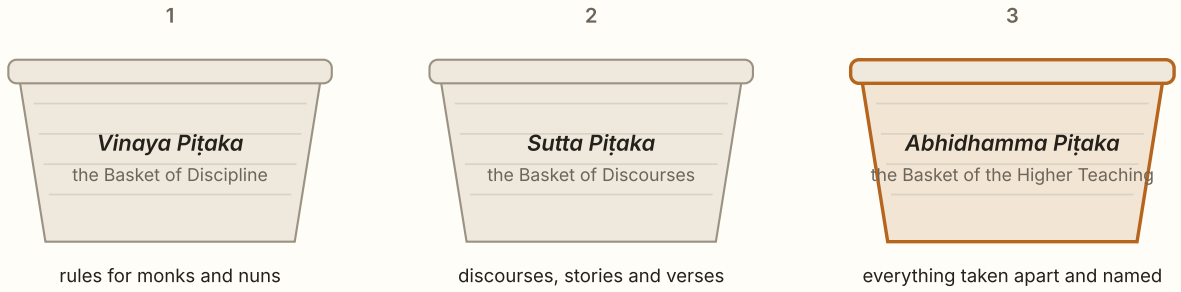
Where it comes from. The course follows a small book, *An Introduction to the Abhidhamma*, printed for free distribution by the Dhamma Study Group in Bangkok in 1980. It has two essays: *Abhidhamma Notes* by Jill Jordan and Richard Giles, which Lessons 1 to 10 follow, and *Abhidhamma and Practice* by Nina van Gorkom, which Lessons 11 and 12 follow. At the back the book has an appendix listing all the *paramattha dhamma* (absolute realities), and the lists in Lessons 3, 4 and 5 come from it. The stories of how the Abhidhamma was taught and handed down come from the ancient commentaries and chronicles: the *Atthasālinī* (The Expositor), the *Dhammapada* commentary and the *Mahāvaṃsa* (the Great Chronicle of Ceylon). A sentence in quotation marks is a quotation from the book or from the ancient texts in translation.

Introduction: what is the Abhidhamma?

> *"Better than a thousand useless words, is one useful word hearing which, one attains peace."*
> *Dhammapada 100, as quoted at the front of the book this course follows.*

The word. *Abhidhamma* is a word in Pali, the language in which the Buddha's teachings were recorded and handed down. *Abhi* means "higher" or "greater". *Dhamma* means "reality[1]" or "truth"; the book says it "can be loosely translated as to mean 'everything which is real'". So *Abhidhamma* means "the higher truth" or "the higher teaching".

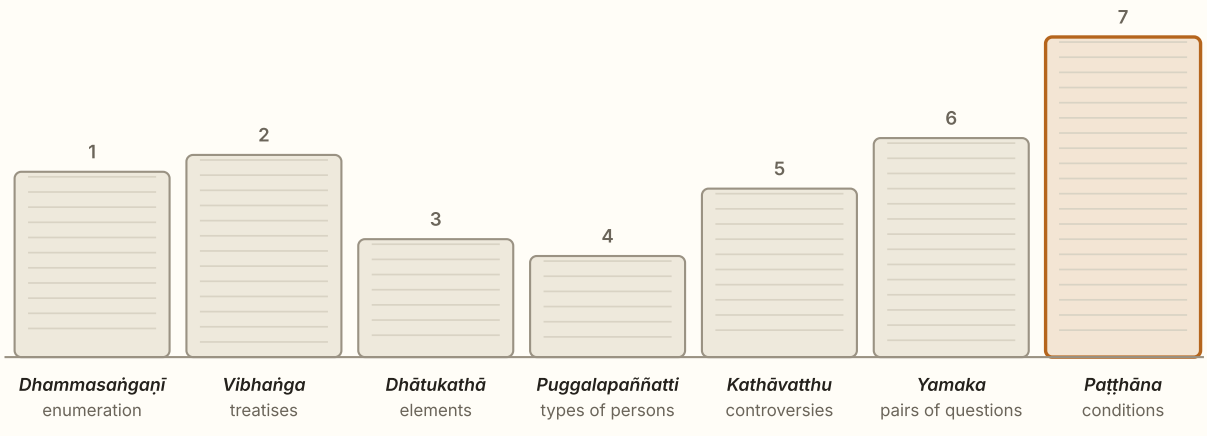
The three baskets. The Buddha's teachings in Pali are called the *Tipiṭaka* (the Three Baskets). The Abhidhamma is the third basket.



"It is the third of the three sections of the Pali Canon (the collected teachings of the Buddha in the Pali language)."

1. The *Vinaya Piṭaka* (the Basket of Discipline): the rules for the monks[2] and nuns[3] of the *Saṅgha* (the order).
2. The *Sutta Piṭaka* (the Basket of Discourses[4]): the discourses, stories and verses given by the Buddha and his disciples[5].
3. The *Abhidhamma Piṭaka* (the Basket of the Higher Teaching): the book calls it "the philosophical[6] and analytical[7] summation[8] of the teachings". It takes everything apart and names every piece.

The seven books. The Abhidhamma is a collection of seven books.



"The Abhidhamma consists of seven books."

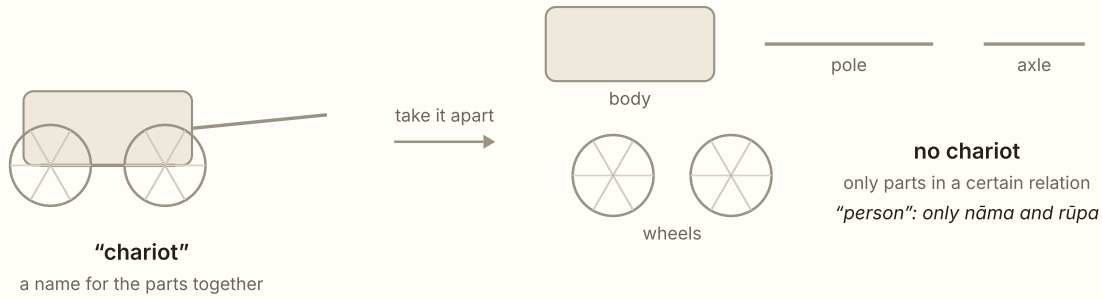
Book	What it is
Dhammasaṅgaṇī	the enumeration[9] of all mental[10] and material[11] phenomena[12]
Vibhaṅga	the book of treatises[13] of all phenomena
Dhātukathā	the discussion of the groups, bases and elements[14] of existence
Puggalapaññatti	the description of individual types of persons
Kathāvatthu	the discussion of points of controversy[15] with schismatic[16] sects
Yamaka	the book of pairs of questions
Paṭṭhāna	the book of origination[17], conditionality and dependence of all the phenomena of existence

The seventh, the *Paṭṭhāna* (the book of conditions[18]), is the largest and the most important Abhidhamma work.

No persons, no places, no things. The books of the Abhidhamma "analyse in minute detail the mental states and material states that comprise what we call our life and what we call the world". In all that detail there is no mention of persons, places or objects[19]. The book says why: "they do not exist in the ultimate[20] sense". A name like "Anna" or "Bangkok" or "table" is a label, useful for talking. What really exists is two sorts of thing: *nāma* (mind, that which experiences[21]) and *rūpa* (matter[22], that which does not experience). What is called a person, a place or a thing is really "different types of mental and material phenomena occurring one after another with extreme rapidity[23] and giving the appearance of a coherent and lasting whole".

The chariot. The ancient teachers explained this with a chariot[24]. The book quotes the *Visuddhimagga* (the Path of Purity[25]), written by the great commentator[26] Buddhaghosa:

> *"Just as the word 'chariot' is but a mode of expression for axle, wheels, chariot-body, pole and other constituent[27] members, placed in a certain relation to each other, but when we come to examine the members one by one, we discover that in the absolute[28] sense there is no chariot. And just as the word 'house' is but a mode of expression for wood and other constituents of a house, surrounding space in a certain relation, but in the absolute sense there is no house. And just as the word 'fist' is but a mode of expression for the fingers, the thumb, etc., in a certain relation, but when we come to examine the parts one by one we discover that in the absolute sense there is no fist; in exactly the same way the words 'living being[29]' and 'ego[30]' are but a mode of expression for the presence of the five attachment[31] groups but when we come to examine the elements of being one by one, we discover that in the absolute sense there is no living being there to form a basis for such figments[32] as 'I am' or 'I'; in other words that in the absolute sense there is only mentality and materiality (nama and rupa)."*



"when we come to examine the members one by one, we discover that in the absolute sense there is no chariot"

The chariot picture is older than Buddhaghosa. In the *Saṃyutta Nikāya* (the Grouped Discourses) a nun called Vajirā is asked by Māra, the tempter, who made "this sentient[33] being". She answers in verse:

> *"This is just a pile of conditions,*
> *you won't find a sentient being here.*
> *When the parts are assembled*
> *we use the word 'chariot'.*
> *So too, when the aggregates[34] are present*
> *'sentient being' is the convention[35] we use."*

Moments. The preface to the book puts it another way. "It is made clear that life exists as moments only. The past moments have gone, they cannot be made to come back. The future has not yet come, so it does not yet exist. The present moment is now and is all that really exists." The moment of seeing is different from the moment of hearing; hearing is different from thinking about what is heard; "even the taste is not the same as the tasting".

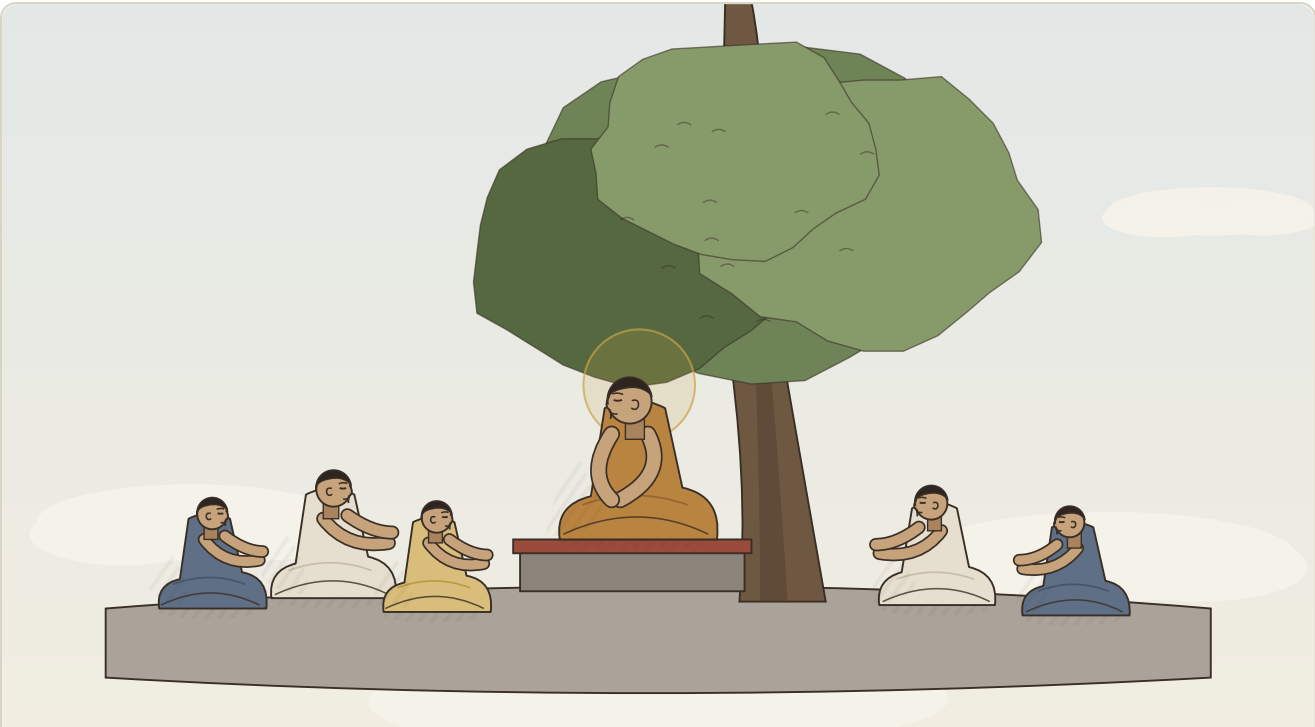
Good and bad. The Abhidhamma sorts all moments of consciousness[36] into four kinds: *kusala* (good) moments, *akusala* (bad) moments, moments that are the result[37] of past causes, and moments that are neither. Through this sorting, the book says, "one establishes also a moral[38] and harmonious[39] way to live so as to benefit oneself and others in the course of life". And in the end, "through Abhidhamma one comes to understand reality as it is so that ignorance[40] of the true nature of reality can be eliminated[41] forever and there is no more cause for going on."

What the lessons cover. Lesson 1 tells how the Abhidhamma was taught and handed down. Lesson 2 explains *nāma* (mind) and *rūpa* (matter) and the four *paramattha dhamma* (absolute realities). Lessons 3, 4 and 5 take *citta* (consciousness), *cetasika* (mental factors[42]) and *rūpa* (matter) one by one. Lesson 6 is about *kamma* (deeds[43]) and *vipāka* (result). Lesson 7 is about birth and death. Lesson 8 is about the four stages of enlightenment[44]. Lesson 9 is about the chain of conditions, the Four Noble Truths and the three marks. Lesson 10 asks what is happening right now. Lessons 11 and 12 follow the second essay in the book, on what the Abhidhamma has to do with practice.

HARD WORDS IN THIS CHAPTER

1. **reality**: something that is really there, not only a name or an idea
2. **monk**: a man who has left home to follow the Buddha's rule of life
3. **nun**: a woman who has left home to follow the Buddha's rule of life
4. **discourse**: a talk or sermon; here, one of the Buddha's talks written down
5. **disciple**: a pupil; someone who follows a teacher
6. **philosophical**: to do with deep thinking about what is true
7. **analyse**: to take something apart carefully to see what it is made of
8. **summation**: a summing up; a short account of the whole
9. **enumerate**: to count up and list one by one
10. **mental**: to do with the mind
11. **material**: made of matter; the stuff that does not know anything
12. **phenomena**: things that happen or appear; here, the realities of mind and matter
13. **treatise**: a long, careful piece of writing on one subject
14. **element**: one of the basic parts that everything is made of
15. **controversy**: an argument between people who disagree
16. **schismatic**: a group that has split off from the main group
17. **origin**: where something comes from; its beginning
18. **condition**: something that has to be there before another thing can happen
19. **object**: the thing that a moment of mind knows: a colour, a sound, a thought
20. **ultimate**: the deepest and most real; what is really there when all the names are taken away
21. **experience**: to know, see, hear or feel something; or the knowing itself
22. **matter**: the kind of reality that does not know or feel anything, such as hardness, colour or sound
23. **rapidity**: great speed
24. **chariot**: a cart with two wheels pulled by horses, used in old times for war and travel
25. **purify**: to make clean; cleanness
26. **commentary**: an old explanation of a text, written to make it clear
27. **constituent**: a part that something is made of
28. **absolute**: complete and real in itself; not depending on names or ideas
29. **being**: any living creature: a person, an animal, a heavenly being
30. **ego**: the self; the idea of 'I'
31. **attachment**: wanting something and holding on to it; liking that will not let go
32. **figment**: something made up; imagined
33. **sentient**: able to feel and know; alive and aware
34. **aggregate**: a group or heap of things taken together
35. **conventional**: the ordinary everyday way of talking, as when a pile of parts is called a chariot
36. **consciousness**: a moment of mind that knows something, such as seeing or hearing
37. **result**: what comes later from a deed done before, as fruit comes from a seed
38. **morality**: good conduct; not killing, not stealing, not lying and the rest
39. **harmonious**: peaceful and well ordered, like music that fits together
40. **ignorance**: not knowing; not understanding what is really there
41. **eliminate**: to get rid of
42. **mental factor**: something that goes along with each moment of mind and does its own small job, such as feeling or remembering
43. **deed**: something done; an act, good or bad
44. **enlightenment**: the moment when the truth is seen fully and for good, and the dirt of the mind is cut away

Lesson 1: how the Abhidhamma came down to us



"The teachings of the Abhidhamma it is said were first taught to the Buddha's mother and residents of some of the heavenly realms"

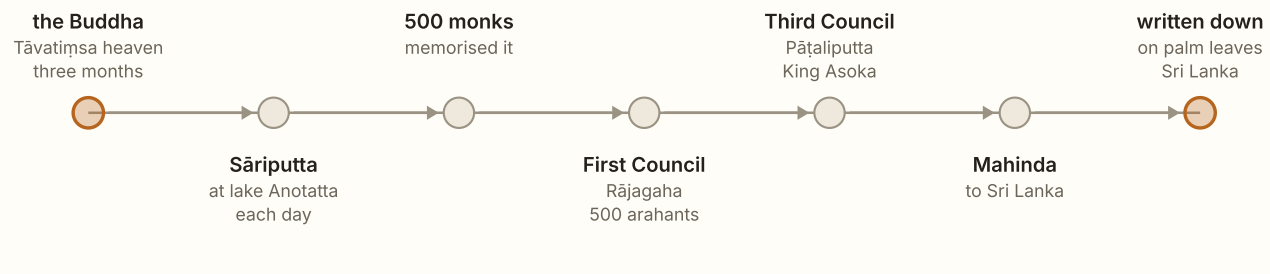
Taught in heaven. The book says that the teachings of the Abhidhamma "were first taught to the Buddha's mother and residents of some of the heavenly realms[1] during a period of three months in the seventh year after the Buddha's enlightenment[2]". The ancient commentary[3] on the first book of the Abhidhamma, the *Atthasālinī* (The Expositor), tells the story in full.

The Buddha's mother, Queen Māyā, had died seven days after he was born, and was reborn[4] as a *deva* (heavenly being[5]) in *Tusita* (the heaven of the contented). In the seventh year after his enlightenment the Buddha went up to *Tāvatiṃsa* (the heaven of the Thirty-three), ruled by *Sakka* (the king of the heavenly beings). He sat on Sakka's stone seat at the foot of the great coral tree. The *devas* (heavenly beings) of ten thousand world systems came to listen, and his mother came down from *Tusita* (the heaven of the contented) to sit at their head. There, for the three months of the rainy season, day and night without a break, the Buddha taught the Abhidhamma.

The created Buddha. A human body cannot go three months without food. So each day, the commentary says, the Buddha created an image of himself, a *nimmita* (created) Buddha, which went on teaching exactly as he would, while he himself went down to the lake Anotatta in the Himalayas to wash, and to the northern land of Uttarakuru for alms[6]. Every day his chief disciple[7] Sāriputta came to wait on him by the lake, and the Buddha told him the method of what had been taught in heaven that day: "so much has been taught".

Sāriputta's five hundred pupils. Sāriputta taught it to his five hundred pupils, "neither too briefly nor too elaborately". Long before, in the time of the Buddha Kassapa, those five hundred had been bats, hanging in a cave where two learned monks[8] used to recite[9] the Abhidhamma. The bats could not understand a word, but they liked the sound of the voices, and they died with that sound in mind. For that they were

reborn as *devas* (heavenly beings), and in the time of our Buddha as human beings, who became monks under Sāriputta. The book says: “Sariputta in turn taught the Abhidhamma to the monks under his instruction, whose role it was to memorise and master it. In this way the seven books of the Abhidhamma have come down to us intact[10].”

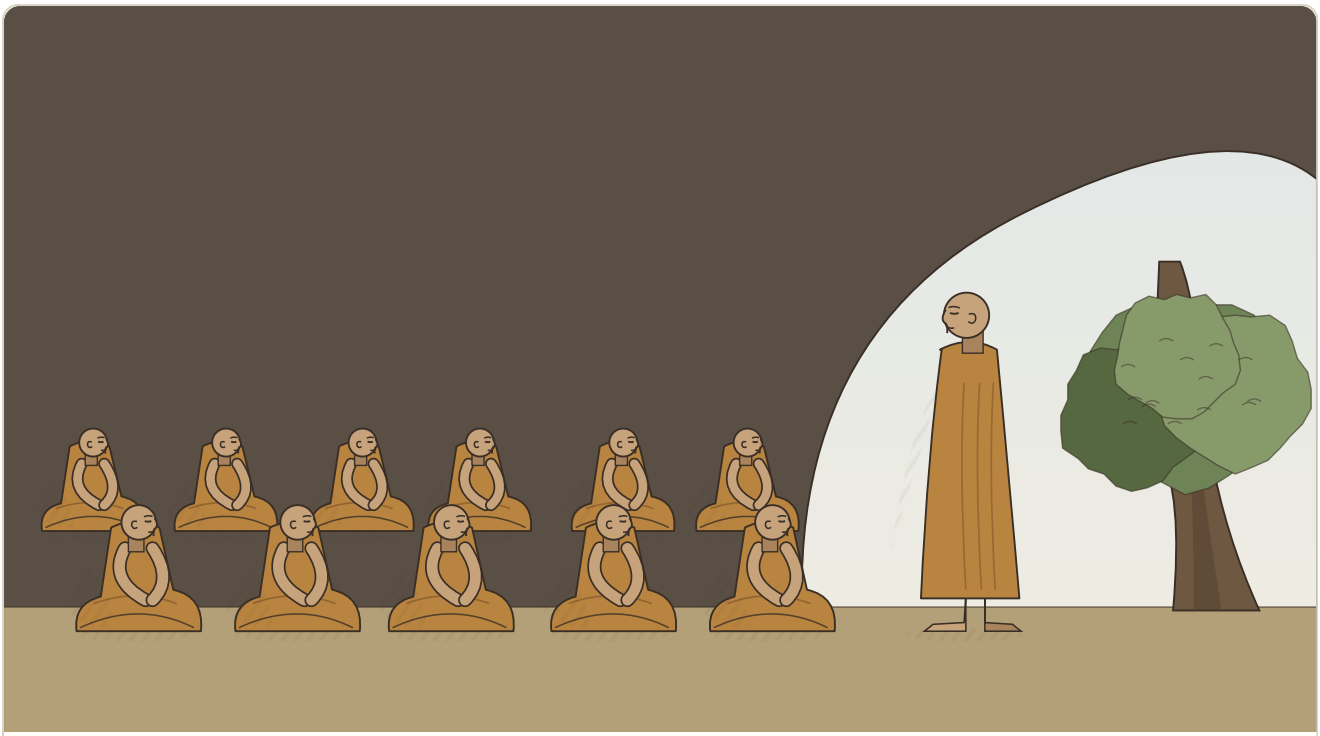


“In this way the seven books of the Abhidhamma have come down to us intact.”

The descent from heaven. When the three months were over, the Buddha came down to the human world at the city of Saṅkassa. The *Dhammapada* commentary tells that Sakka had three staircases made from the top of Mount Sineru, the mountain at the centre of the world, down to the city gate: one of gold for the *devas* (heavenly beings), one of silver for the *Brahmās* (the highest heavenly beings), and one of jewels in the middle for the Buddha.

Why heaven? A *deva* (heavenly being) can sit for three months without eating or sleeping. The Abhidhamma is long, and its sections depend on one another, so it has to be taught without a break.

The First Council. Three months after the Buddha passed away, five hundred *arahants* (fully enlightened disciples) met at Rājagaha, led by the Elder Mahākassapa, and recited the whole teaching together so that it would be remembered exactly. The Elder Upāli recited the *Vinaya* (the discipline) and the Elder Ānanda the *Suttas* (the discourses[11]). The *Atthasālinī* (The Expositor) says the Abhidhamma was recited at that same council[12]. A *saṅgīti* (a council) is a chanting together.



"Previous to this the entire Pali Canon had been committed to memory in verse form by groups of monks"

Carried in memory. For a long time nothing was written down. The book says the entire Pali canon[13] "had been committed to memory in verse form by groups of monks". Each group kept one part. A boy who became a novice[14] learned his part from his teacher word by word, and taught it to his own pupils when he was old.

The Second and Third Councils. A hundred years after the Buddha, seven hundred *arahants* (fully enlightened disciples) met at Vesālī and recited the teaching again. Then, in the reign[15] of King Asoka, who ruled nearly the whole of India, a thousand *arahants* (fully enlightened disciples) met at the capital, Pāṭaliputta, under the Elder Moggaliputta Tissa. At that council the Elder set out the fifth book of the Abhidhamma, the *Kathāvatthu* (Points of Controversy[16]), answering wrong views[17] that had crept in among the monks. He followed a *mātikā* (a table of headings) that the Buddha himself had laid down for the purpose.

Mahinda goes to Sri Lanka. After the Third Council, King Asoka's son, the Elder Mahinda, was sent to the island of Sri Lanka (Ceylon). The *Mahāvaṃsa* (the Great Chronicle[18] of Ceylon) tells how he arrived. The king of the island, Devānampiyatissa, had gone hunting on the Missaka mountain. A *deva* (heavenly being), wanting the king to meet the monks, took the form of a stag[19] and let itself be seen in a thicket[20]. The king chased it up the mountain, and the stag led him to the Elder, who was waiting there with his companions. "Come hither[21], Tissa," said the Elder. The king was alarmed that a stranger called him by name. The Elder said: "Samanas are we, O great king, disciples of the King of Truth. From compassion[22] toward thee[23] are we come hither from Jambudipa."



"Samanas are we, O great king, disciples of the King of Truth."

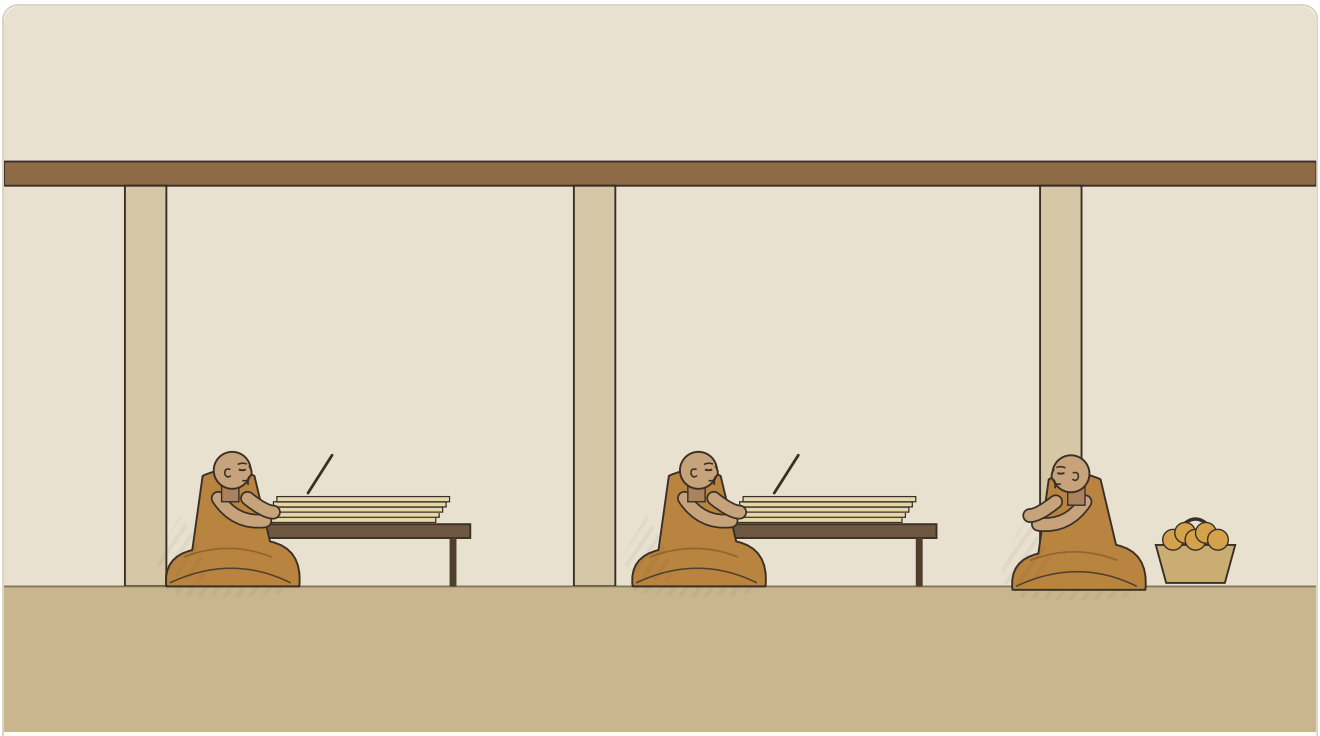
Before he taught, Mahinda wanted to know whether the king was quick enough to follow. So he asked him about a mango tree standing nearby.

> *"What name does this tree bear, O king?"*
> *"This tree is called a mango."*
> *"Is there yet another mango beside this?"*
> *"There are many mango-trees."*
> *"And are there yet other trees besides this mango and the other mangoes?"*
> *"There are many trees, sir; but those are trees that are not mangoes."*
> *"And are there, beside the other mangoes and those trees which are not mangoes, yet other trees?"*
> *"There is this mango-tree, sir."*
> *"Thou hast a shrewd*[24] *wit*[25]*, O ruler of men!"*

"When he had known that he was a keen-witted man," the chronicle says, "the wise thera[26] preached to the monarch" a discourse of the Buddha, the *Cūḷahatthipadopama Sutta* (the Shorter Discourse on the Simile of the Elephant's Footprint). From that time Sri Lanka became the home of the *Tipiṭaka* (the Three Baskets). Mahinda brought the Abhidhamma with the rest, and the commentaries too.

Written down. More than four hundred years after the Buddha, in the reign of King Vaṭṭagāmaṇī Abhaya, the island suffered war and famine[27], and the monks feared that the teaching might be lost if the reciters died. So they met and wrote the whole of it on palm leaves. The *Mahāvaṃsa* (the Great Chronicle of Ceylon) says: "The text of the three pitakas and the atthakatha thereon did the most wise bhikkhus hand down in former times orally, but since they saw that the people were falling away[28] (from religion) the bhikkhus came together, and in order that the true doctrine might endure[29], they wrote them down in

books.” The *aṭṭhakathā* (commentaries) are the ancient explanations of the texts. The book says that from the Third Council onwards the seven books “were considered completed and not subject to alteration[30] in any way”, and that “unaltered copies of the entire Canon have existed in Sri Lanka until the present day”.



“in order that the true doctrine might endure, they wrote them down in books.”

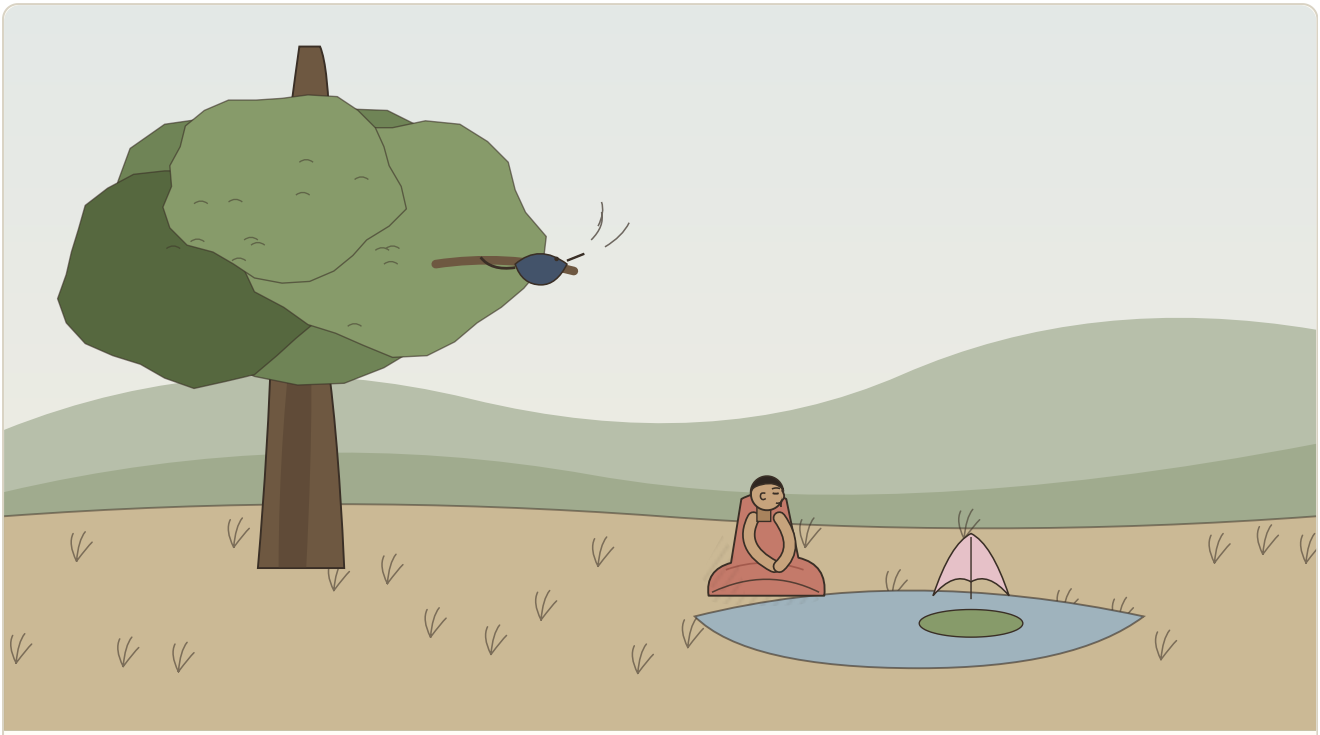
Why it matters. The ancient texts say the seven books are the Buddha’s own teaching, given in heaven, handed to Sāriputta, recited by the *arahants* (fully enlightened disciples) at the councils, carried in memory for four centuries, and written down in Sri Lanka. Every lesson in this course is a small piece of what was taught under the coral tree.

HARD WORDS IN THIS CHAPTER

1. **realm**: a kingdom; here, one of the worlds that beings can be born in
2. **enlightenment**: the moment when the truth is seen fully and for good, and the dirt of the mind is cut away
3. **commentary**: an old explanation of a text, written to make it clear
4. **rebirth**: being born again in a new life after this one ends
5. **being**: any living creature: a person, an animal, a heavenly being
6. **alms**: food given to monks
7. **disciple**: a pupil; someone who follows a teacher
8. **monk**: a man who has left home to follow the Buddha's rule of life
9. **recite**: to say a text aloud from memory
10. **intact**: whole; not damaged or changed
11. **discourse**: a talk or sermon; here, one of the Buddha's talks written down
12. **council**: a big meeting of the elder monks to settle something
13. **canon**: the set of writings accepted as the true teaching
14. **novice**: a boy or young man who has begun training to be a monk
15. **reign**: the time during which a king rules
16. **controversy**: an argument between people who disagree
17. **wrong view**: a wrong idea about what is real, such as the idea that there is a lasting self
18. **chronicle**: a history written down in order of time
19. **stag**: a male deer
20. **thicket**: a thick group of bushes
21. **hither**: here; to this place
22. **compassion**: wanting to help someone who is suffering
23. **thou**: old words for 'you' and 'have'
24. **shrewd**: quick and clever

25. **wit**: cleverness; a quick mind
26. **thera**: an elder monk
27. **famine**: a time when there is no food
28. **fall away**: to end; to stop; to be gone
29. **endure**: to bear something hard without giving up
30. **alteration**: a change

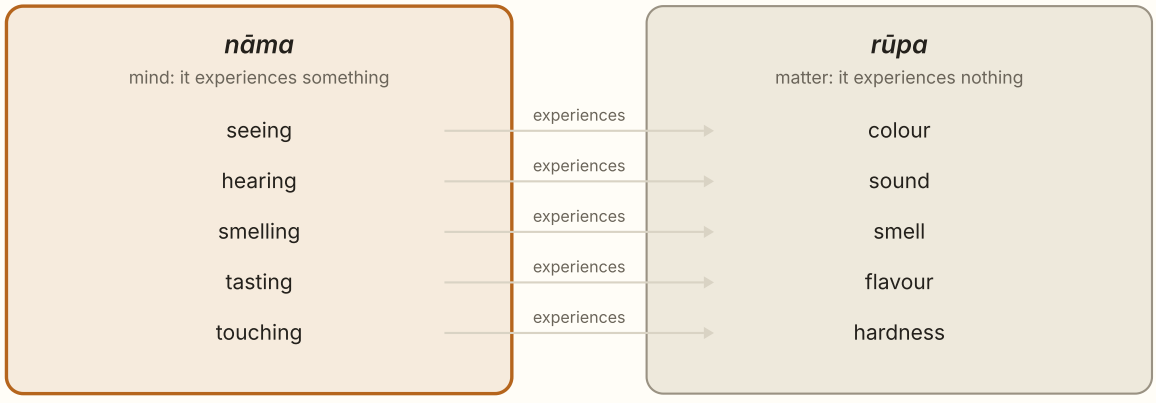
Lesson 2: the two kinds of reality



"Seeing is not hearing. They do not occur together, they occur at different moments"

Nāma and rūpa. The book says: "There are two kinds of absolute[1] realities[2] (paramattha dhammas). They are mental[3] phenomena[4] (nama) and physical or material[5] phenomena (rupa). Nama experiences[6] something. Rupa does not experience anything." That is the whole difference. *Nāma* (mind) knows; *rūpa* (matter[7]) is known and knows nothing.

Seeing. Seeing is a kind of *nāma* (mind): it experiences its object[8], colour, which the book calls "visible data". Colour is a kind of *rūpa* (matter). It does not experience anything. The same goes for all five senses. Seeing, hearing, tasting, touching and smelling each experience an object. The objects, colour, sound, flavour, hardness and smell, are *rūpa* (matter), and experience nothing.



"Nama experiences something. Rupa does not experience anything."

So seeing and what is seen are not the same thing. One knows; the other is known. A child looking at a flower may think that the flower and the seeing are one thing. The Abhidhamma takes them apart: there is colour, which is *rūpa* (matter), and there is seeing, which is *nāma* (mind).

Different moments. Each type of *nāma* (mind) and each type of *rūpa* (matter) is different from every other. Seeing is not hearing. The book says: "They do not occur together, they occur at different moments, although we are under the impression that they do occur together." At the table there seems to be a whole scene at once: the sight of the food, the sound of talking, the taste, the smell, the hardness of the spoon. In reality these are five different experiences, each at its own moment, following one another so fast that they seem to be one.

The six doors. The ancient texts speak of six *dvāra* (doors) through which objects are experienced. Five are the senses; the sixth is the mind.

Door	Object	The *citta* (consciousness[9]) that experiences it
eye	colour	seeing
ear	sound	hearing
nose	smell	smelling
tongue	flavour	tasting
body	hardness, heat, motion	experiencing through the body
mind	*nāma* (mind) and *rūpa* (matter), and concepts[10]	the consciousness that experiences through the mind-door, such as thinking

Each of the five sense-door consciousnesses takes its own object and no other: seeing experiences only colour, hearing only sound. The consciousness at the mind-door can experience *nāma* (mind) and *rūpa* (matter) of every kind, and concepts as well. Thinking about a sound is at the mind-door, and comes after the hearing, which was at the ear-door.

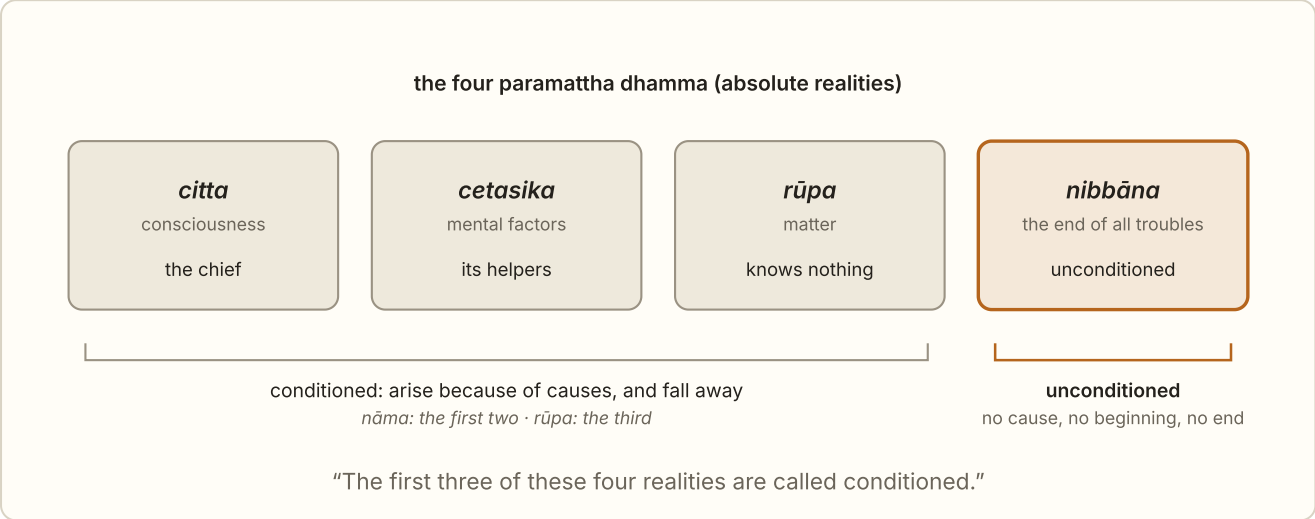
Bāhiya. A discourse[11] in the *Udāna* (the Inspired Utterances) tells of a man called Bāhiya, who wore clothes of bark and was honoured as a holy man, until a *deva* (heavenly being[12]) who had been his friend in a former life told him that he was not enlightened[13] at all, and sent him to the Buddha. Bāhiya hurried to Sāvatthī, found the Buddha on his alms[14] round, and begged him for a teaching there in the street. The Buddha told him:

> *"In that case, Bāhiya, you should train like this: 'In the seen will be merely the seen; in the heard will be merely the heard; in the thought will be merely the thought; in the known will be merely the known.' That's how you should train."*

And he ended: "Just this is the end of suffering[15]." Bāhiya understood at once, and became an *arahant* (fully enlightened) standing there. "In the seen, merely the seen" is this lesson in six words: seeing and colour, and no one who sees.

Never alone. No type of *nāma* (mind) or *rūpa* (matter) can occur by itself. They "can only exist in conjunction with other types of nama and rupa". Seeing needs an eye and a colour; a moment of consciousness arises[16] with mental factors[17].

Three kinds of nāma. *Nāma* (mind) is divided into three kinds. Two are conditioned[18]: they arise because of causes. The third is unconditioned[19]. So the four *paramattha dhamma* (absolute realities) are:



1. *citta* (consciousness)
2. *cetasika* (mental factors, or mental formations)
3. *rūpa* (matter)
4. *nibbāna* (the end of all troubles)

The first three are conditioned. *Nibbāna* (the end of all troubles) is the one unconditioned reality.

What nibbāna is not. *Nibbāna* (the end of all troubles) "is not matter, it is not a place where one goes, it has no form or shape or solidity[20], it is not something that one unites with". It is a mental phenomenon, but different from consciousness and mental factors. It is unconditioned: "there are no causes which make it arise. It does not begin and it does not end. It does not experience anything, but it can be the object of experience." It is experienced by *lokuttara citta* (consciousness beyond the world), the consciousness with fully developed wisdom. And it "cannot be understood intellectually[21]. It can only be directly experienced when wisdom has been sufficiently developed."

Everything else is conditioned. All the other kinds of *nāma* (mind) and *rūpa* (matter) "arise because of past and present causes. They are all conditioned by one another." A moment of seeing arises because there is an eye, a colour, light, attention and the result[22] of a past deed[23]; it falls away[24] at once; another moment follows.

Two truths. The ancient teachers spoke of two kinds of truth. *Sammuti sacca* (conventional[25] truth) is the truth of everyday talk: there is a girl, she is sitting, she sees a flower. That is true in the way that "chariot[26]" is true. *Paramattha sacca* (ultimate[27] truth) is the truth of what is really there: moments of *citta* (consciousness) with their *cetasika* (mental factors), and *rūpa* (matter). The Abhidhamma speaks only the second kind. The *Suttas* (the discourses) often speak the first, because the Buddha spoke to people in the way they could understand. The two do not contradict each other.

A short test. Which of these is *nāma* (mind), and which is *rūpa* (matter)?

- the sound of a bell: *rūpa* (matter), because sound experiences nothing
- hearing the bell: *nāma* (mind), because hearing experiences the sound
- the hardness of the floor: *rūpa* (matter)
- feeling glad: *nāma* (mind)
- the colour of a mango: *rūpa* (matter)
- wanting the mango: *nāma* (mind)

The next three lessons take *citta* (consciousness), *cetasika* (mental factors) and *rūpa* (matter) one at a time.

HARD WORDS IN THIS CHAPTER

1. **absolute**: complete and real in itself; not depending on names or ideas
2. **reality**: something that is really there, not only a name or an idea
3. **mental**: to do with the mind
4. **phenomena**: things that happen or appear; here, the realities of mind and matter
5. **material**: made of matter; the stuff that does not know anything
6. **experience**: to know, see, hear or feel something; or the knowing itself
7. **matter**: the kind of reality that does not know or feel anything, such as hardness, colour or sound
8. **object**: the thing that a moment of mind knows: a colour, a sound, a thought
9. **consciousness**: a moment of mind that knows something, such as seeing or hearing
10. **concept**: an idea put together by thinking, such as 'tree' or 'person'; it cannot be seen or touched by itself
11. **discourse**: a talk or sermon; here, one of the Buddha's talks written down
12. **being**: any living creature: a person, an animal, a heavenly being
13. **enlightenment**: the moment when the truth is seen fully and for good, and the dirt of the mind is cut away
14. **alms**: food given to monks
15. **suffering**: pain and trouble; anything that cannot give lasting happiness
16. **arise**: to come up; to begin; to happen
17. **mental factor**: something that goes along with each moment of mind and does its own small job, such as feeling or remembering
18. **conditioned**: made to happen by other things; it could not come up on its own
19. **unconditioned**: not made by anything; not depending on causes
20. **solidity**: hardness or softness; being solid
21. **intellectual**: to do with thinking and understanding by the mind, not with seeing for oneself
22. **result**: what comes later from a deed done before, as fruit comes from a seed
23. **deed**: something done; an act, good or bad
24. **fall away**: to end; to stop; to be gone
25. **conventional**: the ordinary everyday way of talking, as when a pile of parts is called a chariot
26. **chariot**: a cart with two wheels pulled by horses, used in old times for war and travel
27. **ultimate**: the deepest and most real; what is really there when all the names are taken away

Quiz 1 (lessons 1 and 2)

The answers are at the back.

1. What do the two parts of the word *Abhidhamma* mean?
    - (a) “first” and “rule”
    - (b) “higher” and “reality” or “truth”
    - (c) “old” and “story”
    - (d) “seven” and “book”
2. How many books are there in the *Abhidhamma Piṭaka* (the Basket of the Higher Teaching), and which is the largest?
    - (a) three; the *Vinaya*
    - (b) seven; the *Paṭṭhāna*
    - (c) ten; the *Yamaka*
    - (d) seven; the *Dhammasaṅgaṇī*
3. Where, to whom and for how long did the Buddha first teach the Abhidhamma?
4. How did Sāriputta come to learn the Abhidhamma, and what did he do with it?
5. In the *Mahāvaṃsa* (the Great Chronicle of Ceylon), what led King Devānampiyatissa to the Elder Mahinda?
    - (a) a letter from King Asoka
    - (b) a stag, which was a *deva* (heavenly being) in disguise
    - (c) a dream
    - (d) a mango that fell on his head
6. Why did Mahinda ask the king questions about a mango tree before teaching him?
7. True or false: the Abhidhamma was written down during the Buddha’s lifetime.
8. The book says: “Nama experiences something. Rupa does not experience anything.” Which of these is *rūpa* (matter)?
    - (a) hearing a bell
    - (b) the sound of the bell
    - (c) liking the sound
    - (d) remembering the bell
9. Name the four *paramattha dhamma* (absolute realities). Which one is unconditioned?
10. True or false: seeing and hearing can happen at the same moment.
11. Give three things the book says *nibbāna* (the end of all troubles) is not.

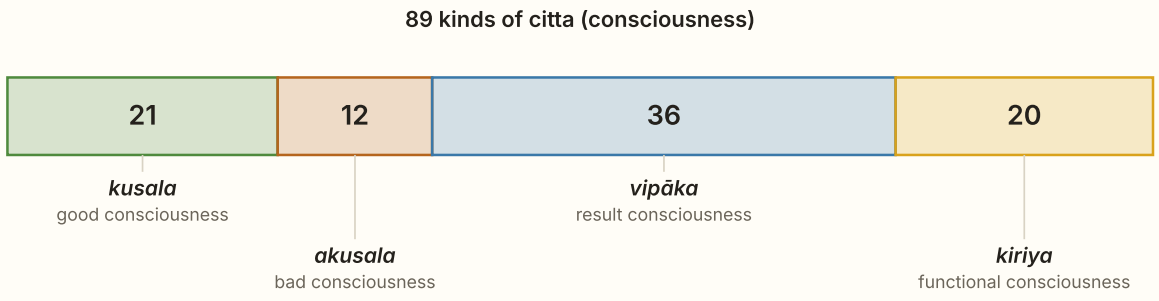
Lesson 3: citta, the chief of the moment



"moments of generosity toward other beings"

The chief. *Citta* (consciousness[1]) "is the chief mental[2] phenomena[3] of experience[4]". In seeing, the *citta* (consciousness) is the one that sees the object[5]. "Citta is the chief experiencer." Everything else in the moment, the *cetasika* (mental factors[6]), helps the *citta* (consciousness) in its own way.

Eighty-nine. The book says: "Citta (consciousness) is of 89 different types." They are sorted into four kinds, which the ancient texts call the four *jāti* (classes) of *citta* (consciousness):



"Citta (consciousness) is of 89 different types. Cittas are divided into four categories"

Kind	Pali	How many
moral[7] or skilful[8] consciousness	*kusala citta* (good consciousness)	21
immoral[9] or unskilful consciousness	*akusala citta* (bad consciousness)	12

Kind	Pali	How many
resultant[10] consciousness	*vipāka citta* (result[11] consciousness)	36
inoperative[12] consciousness	*kiriya citta* (functional[13] consciousness)	20

The first two kinds are causes: they are *kamma* (deeds[14]) in the making, and will bring results in the future. The third kind is the result of causes in the past. The fourth kind is neither cause nor result.

Kusala citta: the good moments. Of the twenty-one kinds of *kusala citta* (good consciousness), eight belong to ordinary daily life. The book says they are divided "according to whether it is accompanied by pleasant or indifferent[15] feeling, with wisdom or without wisdom and prompted[16] or unprompted". So a good moment may be glad or calm; it may understand or not understand; it may arise[17] by itself or after some urging. The other thirteen are nine kinds of consciousness of the *jhāna* (deep calm of mind) and four kinds that experience *nibbāna* (the end of all troubles).

The book's examples of good moments: "moments of generosity[18] toward other beings[19], moments of restraint[20] from lying, killing or stealing, moments of respect for wise people, moments of insight[21] into the true nature of things or moments of meditative[22] absorption practising tranquility[23] meditation". Giving a mango to a friend; holding back from a lie; bowing to a teacher: each is *kusala citta* (good consciousness).

Akusala citta: the bad moments. There are twelve kinds of *akusala citta* (bad consciousness). Eight are rooted in *lobha* (attachment[24]), and these "are accompanied by pleasant or indifferent feeling": wanting something can feel nice, or feel like nothing much. Two are rooted in *dosa* (anger), and these "are accompanied by unpleasant feeling". Two are rooted in *moha* (ignorance[25]) alone, "accompanied by indifferent feeling, one with doubt and one with restlessness[26]".

The book's examples: "when we get angry, when we are bored, when we are depressed, when we are absorbed in beautiful things, when we kill or steal or lie to people or when we are restless". Boredom is on the list, and so is being absorbed in beautiful things.

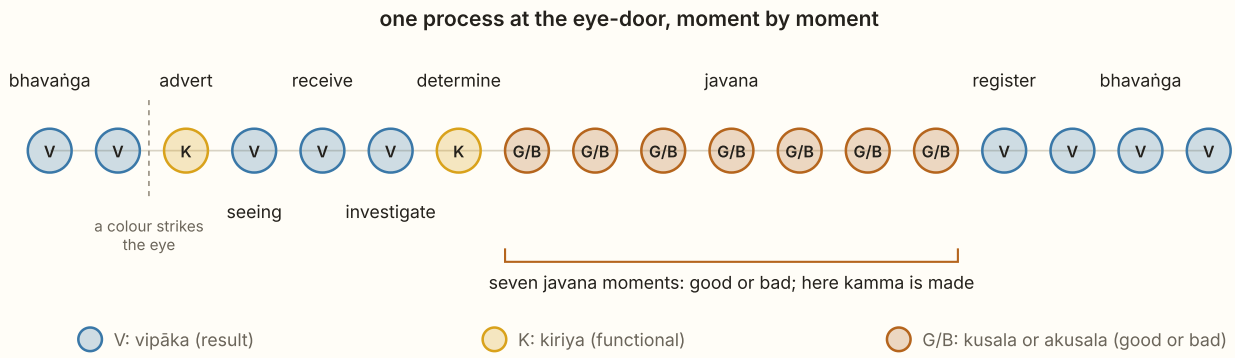
Vipāka citta: the results. The thirty-six kinds of *vipāka citta* (result consciousness) are "the result of previous skillful or unskillful deeds". The book says: "When we see, hear, taste, smell or touch pleasant or unpleasant objects it is result." Seeing a beautiful colour is the result of a good deed in the past. Hearing a harsh sound is the result of a bad deed in the past. The seeing and the hearing themselves are not good or bad; they are results.

Kiriya citta: neither cause nor result. The twenty kinds of *kiriya citta* (functional consciousness) "have no effect in terms of cause and result". The book says they "occur in the sense-door and in thought processes[27] of enlightened[28] beings and again in 9 of the meditative states". When a sound strikes the ear, the first *citta* (consciousness) to turn towards it is a *kiriya citta* (functional consciousness): it only turns to the object, it does not like or dislike. And when an *arahant* (fully enlightened person) smiles or gives or teaches, those moments are *kiriya* (functional) and not *kusala* (good), because an *arahant* (fully enlightened person) makes no more *kamma* (deeds).

The same eighty-nine, sorted by sphere. The appendix to the book sorts the eighty-nine another way, by the *bhūmi* (sphere[29]) they belong to: 54 of the sense sphere, which make up ordinary life; 15 of the form sphere and 12 of the formless sphere, the *jhāna* (deep calm of mind) moments; and 8 *lokuttara citta* (consciousness beyond the world), the four path and four fruit moments that experience *nibbāna* (the end of all troubles).

Five feelings. Every *citta* (consciousness) has a feeling with it. The appendix counts five: pleasant, unpleasant and indifferent mental feeling, and pleasant and unpleasant bodily feeling. Seeing and hearing arise with indifferent feeling. The gladness or sadness comes in the moments that follow.

One process, all four kinds. The ancient texts describe what happens when a colour strikes the eye, moment by moment, in a *vīthi* (a process). Between processes there is a stream of *bhavaṅga citta* (life-continuum[30] consciousness), which keeps the life going while nothing is being seen or heard or thought, as in dreamless sleep. These are *vipāka* (result).



"There is only one moment of consciousness (citta) at a time, and it falls away immediately after it has arisen, but it is succeeded by a next moment."

When a colour strikes the eye-sense, the stream of *bhavaṅga* (life-continuum) is interrupted, and these moments follow one another:

1. *āvajjana* (adverting[31]): a *kiriya citta* (functional consciousness) turns towards the object at the eye-door.
2. *cakkhu-viññāṇa* (seeing): a *vipāka citta* (result consciousness) sees the colour. This is the only moment that sees.
3. *sampaṭicchana* (receiving) and *santīraṇa* (investigating): two more *vipāka* (result) moments take the object on.
4. *votthapana* (determining): a *kiriya citta* (functional consciousness) settles how the object will be taken.
5. *javana* (running): seven moments in a row of *kusala citta* (good consciousness) or *akusala citta* (bad consciousness). Here liking or disliking happens, and *kamma* (deed) is made. In an *arahant* (fully enlightened person) these seven are *kiriya* (functional).
6. *tadārammaṇa* (registering[32]): two *vipāka* (result) moments, and then the *bhavaṅga* (life-continuum) flows again.

So in one process at the eye-door there are *kiriya* (functional), *vipāka* (result), and *kusala* (good) or *akusala* (bad) moments. Then a mind-door process follows, in which the colour is thought about and named. Only then does anyone know "a mango". The seeing itself knew only colour. The whole thing is over in less than the blink of an eye, and it happens again and again, all day long, at every door.

One at a time. Only one *citta* (consciousness) arises at a time. It arises, experiences one object, falls away[33], and the next one arises. There is no second *citta* (consciousness) standing beside it to watch. There is only this moment, and then the next.

A day in cittas. Hearing the cock crow: *vipāka* (result). Not wanting to get up: *akusala* (bad), rooted in *lobha* (attachment) to the warm bed. Getting up to help with the water jars: *kusala* (good). Seeing the sunrise: *vipāka* (result). Being absorbed in how beautiful it is: *akusala* (bad), as the book's list says. Tasting the rice: *vipāka* (result). Wanting a second bowl: *akusala* (bad). Giving the second bowl to a younger brother: *kusala* (good).

HARD WORDS IN THIS CHAPTER

1. **consciousness**: a moment of mind that knows something, such as seeing or hearing
2. **mental**: to do with the mind
3. **phenomena**: things that happen or appear; here, the realities of mind and matter
4. **experience**: to know, see, hear or feel something; or the knowing itself
5. **object**: the thing that a moment of mind knows: a colour, a sound, a thought
6. **mental factor**: something that goes along with each moment of mind and does its own small job, such as feeling or remembering
7. **morality**: good conduct; not killing, not stealing, not lying and the rest
8. **skilful**: done well, with skill; here, good for the mind (unskilful: bad for the mind)
9. **immoral**: bad conduct; wrong
10. **resultant**: coming as a result
11. **result**: what comes later from a deed done before, as fruit comes from a seed
12. **inoperative**: not working as a cause; bringing no result
13. **functional**: doing a job without being a cause or a result
14. **deed**: something done; an act, good or bad
15. **indifferent**: neither pleasant nor unpleasant; in the middle
16. **prompted**: prompted: after some urging; unprompted: of one's own accord
17. **arise**: to come up; to begin; to happen
18. **generosity**: giving freely and gladly
19. **being**: any living creature: a person, an animal, a heavenly being
20. **restraint**: holding oneself back from doing wrong
21. **insight**: seeing into something; here, seeing clearly for oneself that there is only mind and matter
22. **meditation**: developing the mind; people use this word in many different ways
23. **tranquillity**: calm; stillness of mind
24. **attachment**: wanting something and holding on to it; liking that will not let go
25. **ignorance**: not knowing; not understanding what is really there
26. **restlessness**: not being able to be still; a mind that jumps about
27. **process**: a row of moments that follow one another in order
28. **enlightenment**: the moment when the truth is seen fully and for good, and the dirt of the mind is cut away
29. **sphere**: an area or level; here, a level of mind
30. **life-continuum**: the stream of mind that keeps life going when nothing is being seen, heard or thought, as in deep sleep
31. **adverting**: turning towards something
32. **registering**: taking note of
33. **fall away**: to end; to stop; to be gone

Lesson 4: cetasika, the mental factors

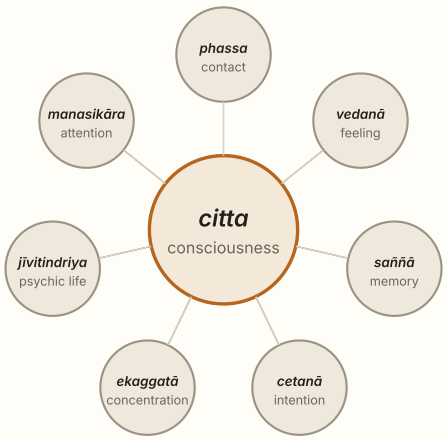


"kindness and hate cannot occur together at the same moment"

The helpers. The other kind of *nāma* (mind) is the *cetasika* (mental factors[1], or mental[2] formations). The book says: "These mental factors arise[3] accompanying each moment of experience[4] (each citta). There is not one moment of experience occurring without at least some of them. Their function[5] is to add to the experience each in their own way." A *citta* (consciousness[6]) never arises alone. It comes with a company of mental factors, and together they make one moment of mind.

Each has its own mark. "Each cetasika or mental factor has its own special characteristic[7] by which it is recognised and function which it performs." The book's example is *māna* (conceit[8]): "the characteristic of conceit is haughtiness and self-praise is its function". Conceit compares: "I am better", or "I am worse", or "I am just as good". Whenever that mark appears, conceit is there, whatever name a person gives it.

Fifty-two. "There are 52 different types of cetasikas." The book names some: "feeling, perception[9] (or memory), contact, intention[10], attention, effort, interest, desire-to-do, restlessness[11], attachment[12], conceit, hate, envy[13], awareness[14], confidence[15], detachment[16], balance of mind, concentration[17], kindness, compassion[18]."



the seven universals, with every citta

7	**universals** with every moment
6	**particulars** with some moments
14	**bad factors** only in bad moments
19	**beautiful factors** in every good moment
3	**abstinences** right speech, action, livelihood
2	**illimitables** compassion, sympathetic joy
1	**wisdom** paññā
52	mental factors in all

"There are seven of these mental factors which occur with every moment of consciousness"

They come in groups. Mental factors "arise with each moment of consciousness in groupings of certain types". Some can never arise together. The book says: "kindness and hate cannot occur together at the same moment, restlessness and balance of mind cannot occur together, compassion and conceit cannot occur together". A moment is either kind or angry; it cannot be both. People say "I love him but I am angry with him", and that is true of a person over an afternoon, but never of one moment.

The seven that are always there. Seven mental factors "occur with every moment of consciousness". The book calls them "the universal[19] cetasikas".

Pali	English	What it does
phassa	contact	touches the object[20], so that the moment meets it
vedanā	feeling	feels the object as pleasant, unpleasant or neither
saññā	perception, or memory	marks the object, so that it can be known again
cetanā	intention	organises the moment and wills; when it is strong it is *kamma* (deed[21])
ekaggatā	concentration	holds the mind on the one object
jīvitindriya	psychic life[22]	keeps the moment alive for its brief time
manasikāra	attention	turns the mind to the object

Even in a moment of seeing there is contact with the colour, a feeling about it, a marking of it, an intention, a holding on it, a life, and an attention to it. The moment is gone before any of it can be noticed.

The other groups. The book lists the rest, and its appendix gives every name.

The 6 *pakiṇṇaka* (particulars), which "occur with particular states of consciousness" and not with all. They can be good or bad depending on the company they keep.

Pali	English
vitakka	initial application, applied thought
vicāra	sustained application
adhimokkha	determination[23], decision
viriya	effort
pīti	interest, joy
chanda	desire-to-do

The 14 *akusala cetasika* (bad mental factors), which “make up all the akusala moments of consciousness”. The first four are in every bad moment.

Pali	English
moha	ignorance[24]
ahirika	lack of moral shame[25]
anottappa	lack of fear of unwholesomeness[26]
uddhacca	restlessness
lobha	attachment
diṭṭhi	wrong view[27]
māna	conceit
dosa	aversion[28], anger
issā	envy
macchariya	stinginess[29]
kukkucca	regret, worry
thīna	sloth[30]
middha	torpor[31]
vicikicchā	doubt

The 19 *sobhana cetasika* (beautiful mental factors), “so called because they are common to all morally[32] beautiful moments of consciousness”. The first seven have names of their own; the other twelve come in six pairs, one for the mental factors and one for the *citta* (consciousness).

Pali	English
saddhā	confidence
sati	mindfulness[33]
hiri	moral shame

Pali	English
ottappa	fear of unwholesomeness[34]
alobha	disinterestedness[35], non-attachment
adosa	amity[36], non-hate
tatramajjhattatā	equanimity[37], balance of mind
passaddhi (composure[38]), a pair	composure
lahutā (lightness), a pair	lightness
mudutā (pliancy[39]), a pair	pliancy
kammaññatā (adaptability[40]), a pair	adaptability
pāguññatā (proficiency[41]), a pair	proficiency
ujukatā (rectitude[42], straightness), a pair	rectitude, straightness

Then the 3 *virati* (abstinences[43]): *sammā vācā* (right speech), *sammā kammanta* (right action) and *sammā ājīva* (right livelihood[44]), which arise when a person holds back from a wrong word, a wrong deed or a wrong way of earning a living. The 2 *appamaññā* (illimitables[45]), "so called because their objects are without limit": *karuṇā* (compassion) and *muditā* (sympathetic joy[46]). And "finally the last sobhana cetasika": *paññā* (wisdom). With the nineteen, these make twenty-five beautiful factors, "arising in various combinations in the wholesome[47] states of consciousness".

Seven and six and fourteen and nineteen and three and two and one make fifty-two.

A moment of anger, taken apart. When a boy's brother breaks his toy cart and anger arises, that one moment of *akusala citta* (bad consciousness) has with it the seven universals, some of the particulars, and from the fourteen bad factors at least these: *dosa* (anger) itself; *moha* (ignorance); *ahirika* (shamelessness) and *anottappa* (fearlessness of wrong), because at that moment there is no shame about being angry and no fear of where it leads; and *uddhacca* (restlessness). If the anger is at the brother for having a better cart, *issā* (envy) may be there. If it is anger at having to share, *macchariya* (stinginess) may be there. If afterwards there is fretting over having shouted, that is *kukkucca* (worry), in a later moment. All nineteen beautiful factors are absent.

Kindness is a mental factor. *Mettā* (loving-kindness[48]) is not a person's feeling; it is the mental factor *adosa* (non-hate), one of the nineteen beautiful ones, when it takes living beings[49] as its object. Compassion is a mental factor. Confidence is a mental factor. So is envy, and so is laziness. None of them belongs to a person. Each arises when its conditions[50] are present, does its work for one moment, and falls away[51]. A kind person is a person in whom kindness arises often.

Why learn the names? Because the names make it possible to notice. When a child knows that there is a mental factor called *issā* (envy), whose mark is being unhappy at someone else's good fortune, then the next time a friend wins a game and something sour arises, it can be known for what it is: not "me being horrible", only *issā* (envy), a conditioned[52] *cetasika* (mental factor), already falling away. The book says that the Abhidhamma "can lead us on to a better understanding of the practise of insight[53]".

HARD WORDS IN THIS CHAPTER

1. **mental factor**: something that goes along with each moment of mind and does its own small job, such as feeling or remembering
2. **mental**: to do with the mind
3. **arise**: to come up; to begin; to happen
4. **experience**: to know, see, hear or feel something; or the knowing itself
5. **function**: the job that something does
6. **consciousness**: a moment of mind that knows something, such as seeing or hearing
7. **characteristic**: the mark by which something is known; what is special about it
8. **conceit**: thinking oneself better than others, or worse, or just as good; pride that compares
9. **perception**: marking something in the mind so that it can be known again; remembering
10. **intention**: what the mind means to do; the mind's choosing
11. **restlessness**: not being able to be still; a mind that jumps about
12. **attachment**: wanting something and holding on to it; liking that will not let go
13. **envy**: being unhappy because someone else has something good
14. **awareness**: noticing what is really there right now; another word for mindfulness
15. **confidence**: trust in what is true and good; sureness
16. **detachment**: not holding on; letting go
17. **concentration**: keeping the mind on one thing
18. **compassion**: wanting to help someone who is suffering
19. **universal**: found in every one; here, mental factors that come with every moment of mind
20. **object**: the thing that a moment of mind knows: a colour, a sound, a thought
21. **deed**: something done; an act, good or bad
22. **psychic life**: the mental factor that keeps a moment of mind alive for its short time
23. **determination**: making up one's mind firmly and keeping to it
24. **ignorance**: not knowing; not understanding what is really there
25. **moral shame**: being ashamed to do wrong
26. **fear of unwholesomeness**: being afraid of the harm that doing wrong brings
27. **wrong view**: a wrong idea about what is real, such as the idea that there is a lasting self
28. **aversion**: not liking something and wanting it to go away; anger, even a little
29. **stinginess**: not wanting to give or share; meanness
30. **sloth**: laziness and dullness of mind
31. **torpor**: heaviness and sleepiness of mind
32. **morality**: good conduct; not killing, not stealing, not lying and the rest
33. **mindfulness**: noticing what is really there right now, without forgetting
34. **unwholesome**: bad for the mind: wanting, anger, not knowing
35. **disinterestedness**: not wanting anything for oneself
36. **amity**: friendliness
37. **equanimity**: an even, calm mind that is not shaken by good luck or bad
38. **composure**: calmness
39. **pliancy**: being soft and bendable, not stiff
40. **adaptability**: being able to fit to what is needed
41. **proficiency**: skill; being good at doing something
42. **rectitude**: straightness; being honest and right
43. **abstain**: to hold back from doing something, such as lying
44. **livelihood**: the way a person earns a living
45. **illimitable**: without limit; boundless
46. **sympathetic joy**: being glad when someone else is happy or does well
47. **wholesome**: good and healthy for the mind: giving, kindness, patience, understanding
48. **loving-kindness**: wishing others well; friendliness to everyone
49. **being**: any living creature: a person, an animal, a heavenly being
50. **condition**: something that has to be there before another thing can happen
51. **fall away**: to end; to stop; to be gone
52. **conditioned**: made to happen by other things; it could not come up on its own
53. **insight**: seeing into something; here, seeing clearly for oneself that there is only mind and matter

Quiz 2 (lessons 3 and 4)

The answers are at the back.

1. How many kinds of *citta* (consciousness) does the Abhidhamma count, and in how many classes?
    - (a) 52 kinds in 7 classes
    - (b) 89 kinds in 4 classes
    - (c) 28 kinds in 2 classes
    - (d) 31 kinds in 3 classes
2. Put the four classes of *citta* (consciousness) in order, from the fewest kinds to the most.
    - *kusala citta* (good consciousness), 21
    - *kiriya citta* (functional consciousness), 20
    - *akusala citta* (bad consciousness), 12
    - *vipāka citta* (result consciousness), 36
3. Which of these is on the book's list of examples of *akusala citta* (bad consciousness)?
    - (a) being bored
    - (b) bowing to a teacher
    - (c) holding back from a lie
    - (d) seeing a beautiful colour
4. Seeing a pleasant colour: is that *kusala* (good), *akusala* (bad) or *vipāka* (result)? Why?
5. Which feeling always goes with *citta* (consciousness) rooted in *dosa* (anger)?
    - (a) pleasant feeling
    - (b) indifferent feeling
    - (c) unpleasant feeling
    - (d) any of the three
6. What does *kiriya citta* (functional consciousness) mean, and when does it arise?
7. The book says one mental factor has "haughtiness" as its characteristic and "self-praise" as its function. Which?
    - (a) *issā* (envy)
    - (b) *māna* (conceit)
    - (c) *dosa* (anger)
    - (d) *uddhacca* (restlessness)
8. Name the seven universal *cetasika* (mental factors), which arise with every moment of consciousness.
9. True or false: kindness and hate can arise together in one moment of consciousness.
10. How many *cetasika* (mental factors) are there in all?
    - (a) 7
    - (b) 28
    - (c) 52
    - (d) 89
11. Which mental factor is *mettā* (loving-kindness), according to the Abhidhamma?

Lesson 5: rūpa, matter



"The four great elements always arise with those rupas which are known as the derived rupas."

Twenty-eight. The third conditioned[1] reality[2] is *rūpa* (matter[3]). The book says: "There are 28 classes of rupa, 16 being classified[4] as subtle[5] and 12 as gross[6]." Gross means the kinds that strike the senses directly: the five sense organs and the seven objects[7] that can be seen, heard, smelt, tasted or touched. Subtle means the finer kinds.

The four great elements. At the base of all matter are the four *mahābhūta* (great elements[8]). The book gives them with their real meanings:

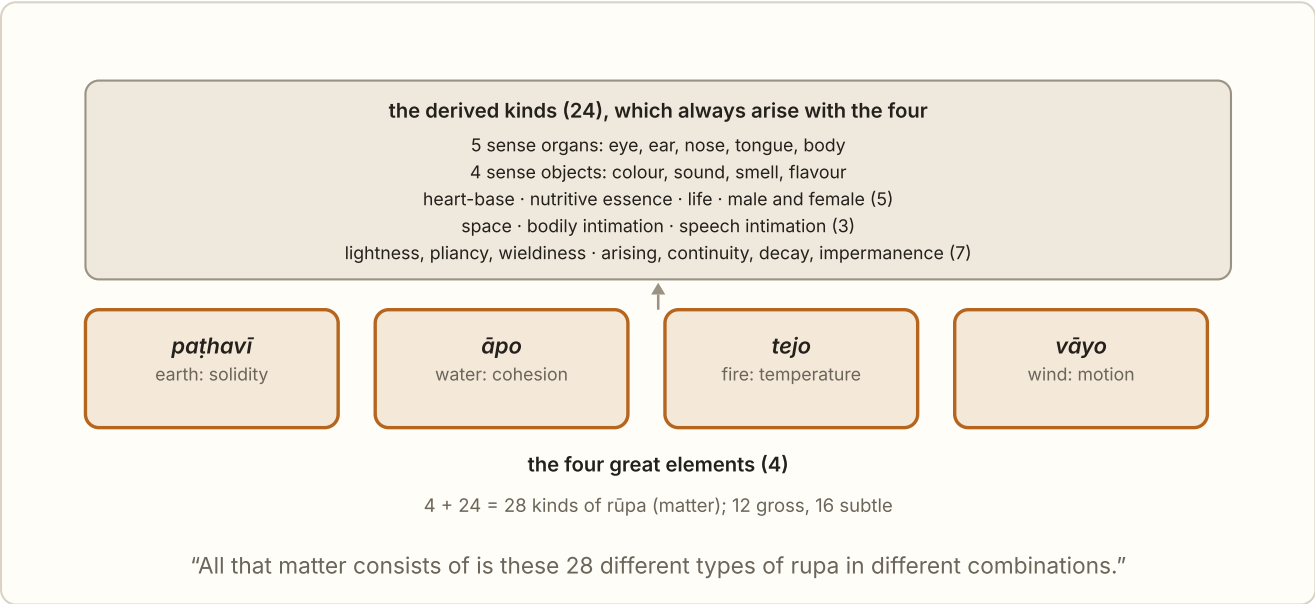
1. *paṭhavī dhātu* (the element of earth), or solidity[9]
2. *āpo dhātu* (the element of water), or cohesion[10]
3. *tejo dhātu* (the element of fire), or temperature
4. *vāyo dhātu* (the element of wind), or motion

These are not the earth in the garden, the water in the well, the fire on the hearth and the wind in the trees. They are qualities. Earth is hardness and softness. Water is the holding together of the parts. Fire is heat and cold. Wind is motion and pressure. A stone has all four: it is hard, it holds together, it has a temperature, and it presses on the hand that holds it. So does a drop of water, and so does the body. A thing is never only "earth"; it is a group in which one element is strongest.

The elements in the body. In the *Dhātuvibhaṅga Sutta* (the Discourse[11] on the Analysis of the Elements), the Buddha taught a young man called Pukkusāti, in a potter's workshop, to see his own body as the four elements. What is hard in the body is the earth element: the hair, the nails, the teeth, the skin, the flesh, the bones, and the rest. What is fluid and holds together is the water element: blood, sweat, tears, and the rest.

What warms the body and digests what is eaten is the fire element. What moves in the body, the breath going in and out, is the wind element. And of each he taught: this is not mine, this is not what I am, this is not my self. The earth element inside the body and the earth element in a rock are the same element.

The derived kinds. "The four great elements always arise[12] with those rupas which are known as the derived[13] rupas." Derived means depending on the four, as a pot depends on clay. The book names them: "the physical sense-organs of eye-sense, ear-sense, taste-sense, etc., and the sense-objects of colour, sound, smell and flavour". The eye-sense is not the eyeball; it is the fine matter inside the eye that can be struck by colour. Then there are "the male or female characteristic[14], heart-base, nutritive[15] essence (food), space, lightness, bodily intimation[16], speech intimation, etc." Bodily intimation is the matter by which the body makes its meaning known, as when a hand beckons. Speech intimation is the matter by which speech makes its meaning known. The heart-base is the matter on which most kinds of *citta* (consciousness[17]) depend, as seeing depends on the eye-sense.



All matter. The book says: "All that matter consists of is these 28 different types of rupa in different combinations." A mountain, a mango, a hand, a sound, a smell: twenty-eight kinds, in groups.

Rūpa does not know. *Rūpa* (matter) does not experience[18] anything. In the last lesson of the book: "Hardness is a type of rupa (matter). It cannot know anything about anything." The hardness of a bench does not know that someone is sitting on it. The colour of a face does not know that it is seen. When a person says "the bench is hard", there are two realities: hardness, which is *rūpa* (matter), and the experience of hardness through the body-sense[19], which is *nāma* (mind).

The eightfold group. *Rūpa* (matter) never arises as a single kind. The appendix to the book says that matter "consists of 8 basic constituents[20] which compose all matter", the *suddhaṭṭhaka kalāpa* (the pure eightfold group): the four great elements and four derived from them.

Pali	English
paṭhavī	solidity
āpo	cohesion

Pali	English
tejo	temperature
vāyo	motion
vaṇṇa	colour
gandha	smell
rasa	taste
ojā	nutriment

Where there is hardness there is also colour, smell, taste and nutriment, whether anyone notices them or not. The appendix then lists "a further 20 types of matter, all of which are also derived rupas": the five sense organs; the male and female characteristic, which counts as two; the heart base; the material[21] life-principle; space; bodily intimation; speech intimation; sound; lightness, plasticity and adaptability[22]; and growth, continuity, decay and impermanence[23]. "The fourteenth type, male and female characteristic, is of two types which makes a total of 28 rupas." Groups of matter in the body arise from four sources: from *kamma* (deeds[24]), from *citta* (consciousness), from temperature and from food. The eye-sense and the heart-base are produced by *kamma* (deeds). The movement of the hand that beckons is produced by *citta* (consciousness).

Rūpa falls away. Matter lasts longer than mind, but not long. The ancient texts say that one group of *rūpa* (matter) lasts as long as seventeen moments of *citta* (consciousness), and then it is gone, and another group has taken its place. The body that sat down is not the body that stands up.

The five khandhas. The ancient texts have one more way of sorting everything met in Lessons 3, 4 and 5. The appendix to the book calls them the five *khandha* (aggregates[25], or groups), "the aggregates of our daily existence":

1. *rūpa-khandha* (the group of matter): all twenty-eight kinds of *rūpa* (matter), "hardness, temperature, pressure, colour, smell, taste"
2. *vedanā-khandha* (the group of feeling): the mental factor[26] feeling, in its five kinds
3. *saññā-khandha* (the group of perception[27], or memory): the mental[28] factor that "marks the object of experience so that it can be recognised now and in the future"
4. *saṅkhāra-khandha* (the group of mental formations): "the other fifty cetasikas"
5. *viññāṇa-khandha* (the group of consciousness): "all types of citta"

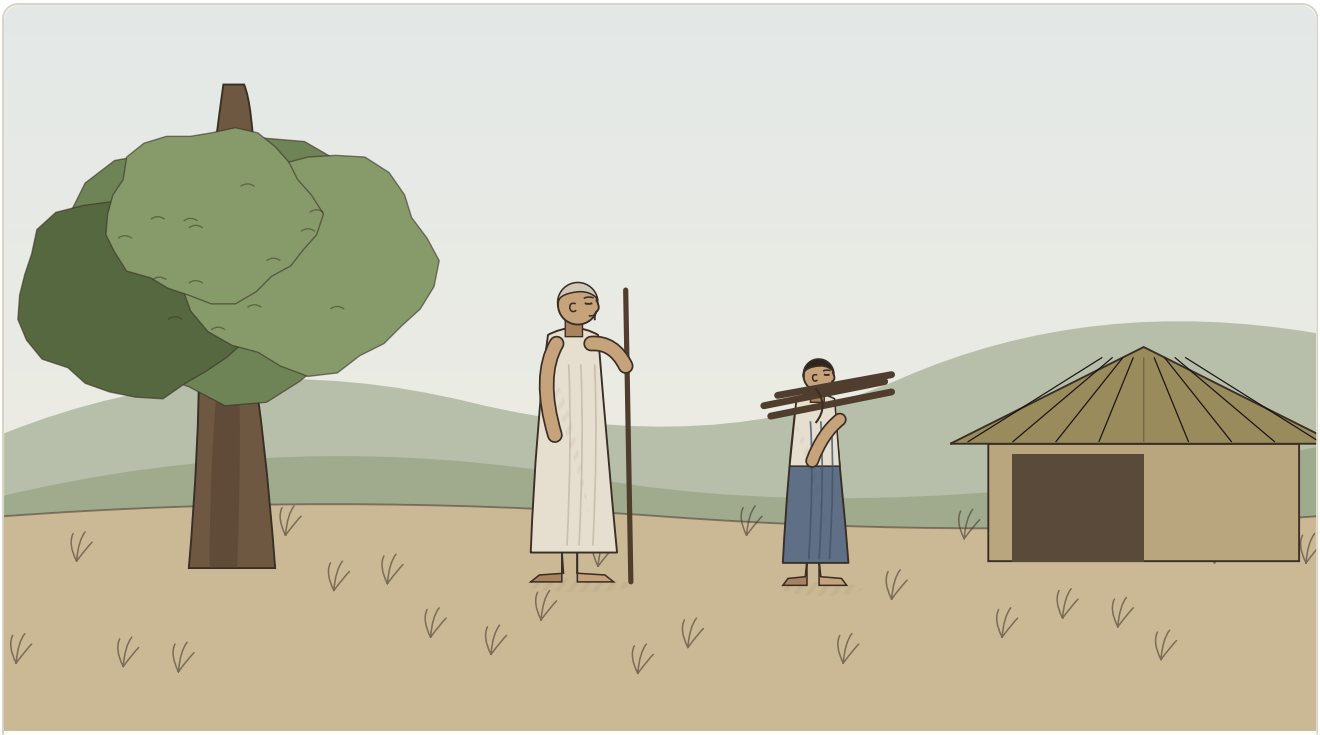
The appendix says: "The khandhas are called the 'groups of grasping[29]'. This means that we cling[30] to, or grasp at these aggregates as belonging to a self. As long as we take them for self we do not understand them as they really are, just paramattha dhammas, just conditioned realities." When the nun[31] Vajirā said, in the Introduction, that "when the aggregates are present 'sentient[32] being[33]' is the convention[34] we use", these five groups were what she meant.

HARD WORDS IN THIS CHAPTER

1. **conditioned**: made to happen by other things; it could not come up on its own
2. **reality**: something that is really there, not only a name or an idea

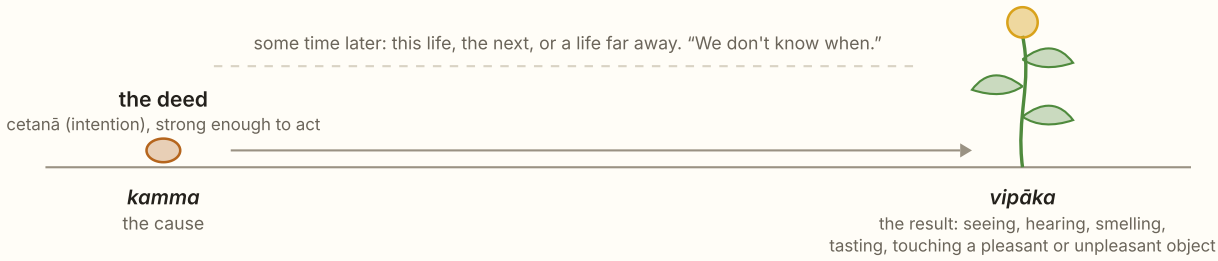
3. **matter**: the kind of reality that does not know or feel anything, such as hardness, colour or sound
4. **classification**: sorting things into kinds
5. **subtle**: fine, faint and hard to notice
6. **gross**: here, coarse and easy to notice; not 'disgusting'
7. **object**: the thing that a moment of mind knows: a colour, a sound, a thought
8. **element**: one of the basic parts that everything is made of
9. **solidity**: hardness or softness; being solid
10. **cohesion**: holding together; the sticking-together of the parts
11. **discourse**: a talk or sermon; here, one of the Buddha's talks written down
12. **arise**: to come up; to begin; to happen
13. **derived**: coming from something else and depending on it
14. **characteristic**: the mark by which something is known; what is special about it
15. **nutriment**: food; what feeds the body and keeps it going
16. **intimation**: a sign that makes a meaning known, as a nod or a word does
17. **consciousness**: a moment of mind that knows something, such as seeing or hearing
18. **experience**: to know, see, hear or feel something; or the knowing itself
19. **bodysense**: the sense of touch, all over the body
20. **constituent**: a part that something is made of
21. **material**: made of matter; the stuff that does not know anything
22. **adaptability**: being able to fit to what is needed
23. **impermanent**: not lasting; passing away
24. **deed**: something done; an act, good or bad
25. **aggregate**: a group or heap of things taken together
26. **mental factor**: something that goes along with each moment of mind and does its own small job, such as feeling or remembering
27. **perception**: marking something in the mind so that it can be known again; remembering
28. **mental**: to do with the mind
29. **grasping**: holding on tightly; clinging
30. **clinging**: holding on tightly; not wanting to let go
31. **nun**: a woman who has left home to follow the Buddha's rule of life
32. **sentient**: able to feel and know; alive and aware
33. **being**: any living creature: a person, an animal, a heavenly being
34. **conventional**: the ordinary everyday way of talking, as when a pile of parts is called a chariot

Lesson 6: kamma and vipāka, deeds and their results



"Moral action, whenever performed, will always bring a pleasant result at some time in the future."

Seeing is a result. The book says: "Whenever we see, hear, taste, smell or touch an object[1], that experience[2], as was mentioned before, is resultant[3]-consciousness[4] (vipaka-citta). It is the result[5] of a deed[6] performed at some time in the past." A pleasant sight is the result of a good deed; an unpleasant sound is the result of a bad one. Nobody chooses what will strike the eye and the ear in the next moment. "The area of cause and result (kamma and vipaka) is most important in Abhidhamma. To sort out experience into cause and result can cast our lives into a much clearer perspective[7]."



"It is the result of a deed performed at some time in the past."

Twenty kinds of deed. "The Buddha enumerated[8] ten types of moral[9] and skillful[10] action and ten types of immoral[11] or unskillful action through body, speech or mind. Moral action, whenever performed, will always bring a pleasant result at some time in the future. Immoral action will always bring an unpleasant result." The ten *akusala kamma* (bad deeds) are:

Through	Pali	English
body	*pāṇātipāta*	killing
body	*adinnādāna*	stealing
body	*kāmesu micchācāra*	sexual misconduct[12] (being unfaithful to a husband or wife)
speech	*musāvāda*	lying
speech	*pisuṇā vācā*	slandering[13]
speech	*pharusā vācā*	rude speech
speech	*samphappalāpa*	frivolous[14] talk
mind	*abhijjhā*	covetousness[15], wanting what belongs to others
mind	*vyāpāda*	ill will[16]
mind	*micchā diṭṭhi*	wrong view[17]

The book says: “These ten types of action whenever performed, no matter what the justification[18] that we make for them, are always immoral actions and capable of producing an unpleasant result.” It gives examples of things people excuse: killing insects, cheating on taxes, abusive[19] speech. And about killing: “the Buddha pointed out that destruction of other being’s lives is never to the welfare of oneself or the other being. The justification for killing is just thinking, but the actual moment of killing is always immoral and never to anybody’s benefit.”

Ten kinds of good deed. The ten *puñña kiriya vatthu* (bases of meritorious[20] action) are:

Pali	English
dāna	generosity[21]
sīla	restraint[22] (from lying, killing and so on)
bhāvanā	mental[23] development (tranquillity[24] and insight[25])
apacāyana	respect (for teachers, parents, the Buddha and so on)
veyyāvacca	service (being helpful)
pattidāna	sharing of merit (with beings[26] in other planes[27])
pattānumodana	rejoicing[28] in others’ merit
dhammassavana	listening to Dhamma (the teaching)
dhammadesanā	teaching Dhamma (the teaching)
diṭṭhijukamma	straightening one’s views (understanding)

The book remarks that some of these “are not very popular these days. Respect for teachers and parents, and for other’s opinions, is something we don’t practise very much. Sharing of merit is not practised at all in western countries today.” Sharing of merit means, after a good deed, wishing that beings in other planes may rejoice in it too. Rejoicing in others’ merit is the opposite of envy[29]. “The last three types are

concerned with the teaching of Buddha-dhamma. When we teach, listen and understand sincerely[30] then this is a moral action." So listening to this lesson with a sincere wish to understand is itself *kusala kamma* (a good deed).

What kamma really is. *Kamma* (deed) is not a law outside a person, and not a ledger kept somewhere. The book says: "Kamma (or karma) can also be understood more precisely as the cetasika or mental factor[31] called intention[32] (cetana). There is intention arising[33] with every moment of consciousness as it is a universal[34] mental factor." Most of the time it is weak. "When intention is strong enough to motivate deeds through body or speech then the intensity of intention (cetana) is stronger. When intention motivates one of the ten types of moral or immoral actions through body, speech or mind then it is called kamma because it is strong enough to produce a result at some time in the future." So *kamma* (deed) is *cetanā* (intention) grown strong enough to act.

Results in a life. The book lists the unpleasant things that come to everyone: "sickness, disease, accidents"; people who "abuse us" or "misrepresent[35] us"; "our bodies wear out". And the pleasant things: "we meet friendly people, we receive gifts, we have a strong body, we have good eyesight, we have a beautiful partner, we live in a pleasant house with beautiful children. All of these things happen to us because of deeds performed at some time in the past, we don't know when." People arrange their lives around the pleasant results they hope for: "we want a nice house, we want peace and quiet", "we look forward to delicious, well-prepared food. But these things come to us only because of moral deeds we have performed in the past."

Then the book draws the conclusion. "The only way to receive more of this is not to climb over the next man, not to cheat on tax, not to lie about our qualifications[36], not to abuse other people, but to be kind, respectful, generous, honest and upright[37] in character. The Buddha taught quite clearly that it is deeds in the past that determine our life situation right now."

Not knowing when. A good deed does not bring its result at once. The result may come in this life, in the next, or in a life far away. The deed is a seed; the result is the fruit; and between them there may be a long time. Every moment of seeing, hearing, smelling, tasting and touching is a fruit of some seed planted before.

Two moments to tell apart. Suppose a boy hears a rude word. The hearing is *vipāka* (result): the fruit of a past deed, and nothing can be done about it now. What comes next is not result. If anger arises, that is *akusala citta* (bad consciousness), a new seed. If patience arises, that is *kusala citta* (good consciousness), a new seed of a different kind. The moment of result is closed; the moment after it is open.

HARD WORDS IN THIS CHAPTER

1. **object**: the thing that a moment of mind knows: a colour, a sound, a thought
2. **experience**: to know, see, hear or feel something; or the knowing itself
3. **resultant**: coming as a result
4. **consciousness**: a moment of mind that knows something, such as seeing or hearing
5. **result**: what comes later from a deed done before, as fruit comes from a seed
6. **deed**: something done; an act, good or bad
7. **perspective**: a way of seeing things; a view
8. **enumerate**: to count up and list one by one
9. **morality**: good conduct; not killing, not stealing, not lying and the rest
10. **skilful**: done well, with skill; here, good for the mind (unskilful: bad for the mind)
11. **immoral**: bad conduct; wrong

12. **misconduct**: bad behaviour
13. **slander**: saying untrue, unkind things about someone to other people
14. **frivolous**: silly and useless
15. **covetousness**: wanting what belongs to someone else
16. **ill will**: wishing someone harm
17. **wrong view**: a wrong idea about what is real, such as the idea that there is a lasting self
18. **justification**: a reason given to make something seem right
19. **abuse**: to treat or speak to someone cruelly and rudely
20. **merit**: goodness earned by a good deed, which brings a good result later
21. **generosity**: giving freely and gladly
22. **restraint**: holding oneself back from doing wrong
23. **mental**: to do with the mind
24. **tranquillity**: calm; stillness of mind
25. **insight**: seeing into something; here, seeing clearly for oneself that there is only mind and matter
26. **being**: any living creature: a person, an animal, a heavenly being
27. **plane**: a world or level where beings live: the human world, the heavens, the animal world and so on
28. **rejoice**: to be glad
29. **envy**: being unhappy because someone else has something good
30. **sincere**: truly meant; honest
31. **mental factor**: something that goes along with each moment of mind and does its own small job, such as feeling or remembering
32. **intention**: what the mind means to do; the mind's choosing
33. **arise**: to come up; to begin; to happen
34. **universal**: found in every one; here, mental factors that come with every moment of mind
35. **misrepresent**: to describe someone wrongly; to give a false picture of them
36. **qualification**: a paper that shows what one has learnt or can do
37. **upright**: honest and good

Quiz 3 (lessons 5 and 6)

The answers are at the back.

1. How many kinds of *rūpa* (matter) are there, and how are they divided?
    - (a) 28: 12 gross and 16 subtle
    - (b) 52: 7 universal and 45 particular
    - (c) 89: 4 classes
    - (d) 4: earth, water, fire and wind
2. Name the four great elements with the quality each one really means.
3. True or false: hardness can know that someone is sitting on it.
4. Which of these is a derived *rūpa* (matter) named in the book?
    - (a) seeing
    - (b) the eye-sense
    - (c) feeling
    - (d) doubt
5. What is the smallest group in which *rūpa* (matter) arises, and what is in it?
6. The book says seeing, hearing, tasting, smelling and touching are:
    - (a) *kusala* (good) deeds
    - (b) the results of deeds done in the past
    - (c) *kiriya* (functional) moments
    - (d) mental factors
7. Put these in order, from the first moment to the last.
    - one of the ten good or bad deeds is done: this is *kamma* (deed)
    - the intention grows strong enough to move the body or the speech
    - *cetanā* (intention) arises with a moment of consciousness, as it does with every moment
    - at some time in the future, a pleasant or unpleasant result arises as seeing, hearing, smelling, tasting or touching
8. What does the book say about the "justification" people give for killing?
9. Which of these is one of the ten *puñña kiriya vatthu* (bases of meritorious action)?
    - (a) rejoicing in others' merit
    - (b) winning a race
    - (c) owning many books
    - (d) being born rich
10. What exactly is *kamma* (deed), according to the Abhidhamma?
11. True or false: the book says sharing of merit is one of the most popular good deeds in western countries.
12. Finish the book's sentence: "The only way to receive more of this is not to climb over the next man … but to be …"

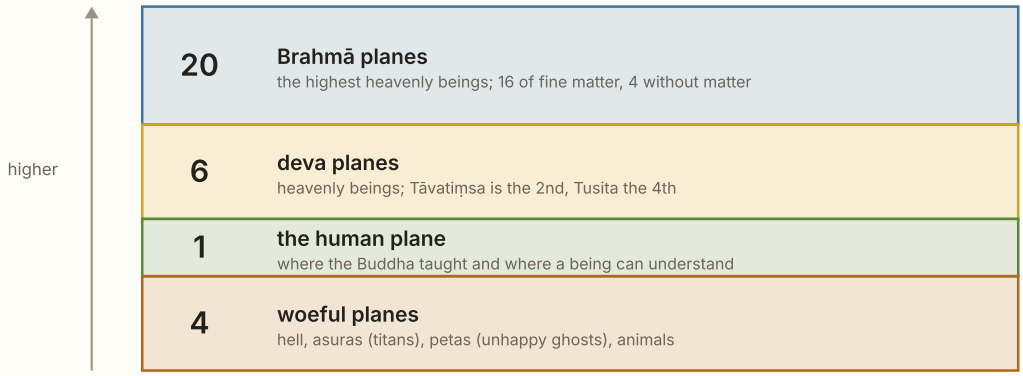
Lesson 7: the wheel of birth and death



"Nay, to supply them all, the straw, boughs, twigs and leaves in this India would come to an end and be used up, ere this were done."

A wheel, not a ladder. "Birth and death are dealt with in minute detail in the Abhidhamma." The book says: "The Buddha taught that life or existence is a cyclic process[1] with beings[2] dying and passing on to other existences according to their moral[3] and immoral[4] deeds[5]." Some teachings say that a being can never be born into a worse life than its present one, as if life were a ladder that only goes up. The Buddha did not teach that. "The Buddha maintains that life, far from being necessarily progressive, can for many beings be a destructive and downward process. He likens it a wheel turning around and around with no end to it. Beings are ever repeating mistakes or performing deeds due to their ignorance[6] of the way things are which will bring them more and more unhappiness in the future." The ancient texts call this wheel *saṃsāra* (the round of births).

Thirty-one planes. "The Buddha enumerated[7] 31 planes[8] of existence through which beings continually pass according to their deeds." The book counts them: "There are 4 woeful[9] or unhappy planes, the human plane, 6 planes of angels (or devas) and 20 planes of brahmas or gods."



31 planes; all of them temporary; beings pass round and round through them

"The Buddha enumerated 31 planes of existence through which beings continually pass according to their deeds."

Planes	How many	Who lives there
apāya (woeful planes)	4	beings in hell, *asuras* (titans[10]), *petas* (unhappy ghosts), animals
manussa (the human plane)	1	human beings
deva planes (heavens of the sense world)	6	*devas* (heavenly beings)
Brahmā planes	20	*Brahmās* (the highest heavenly beings): 16 planes of fine matter[11] and 4 planes without matter

Tāvatiṃsa (the heaven of the Thirty-three), where the Abhidhamma was taught, is the second of the six *deva* (heavenly) planes. *Tusita* (the heaven of the contented), where the Buddha's mother was reborn[12], is the fourth.

All of them end. "Existence in all of these planes has one thing in common, it is temporary, it does not last. A being born into any plane of existence has to eventually pass out of it and be reborn elsewhere. So then heaven is not the end of it all, it is only one plane of existence from which a being must eventually fall again to a lower existence. Life in the heavenly planes is of course exceedingly pleasant and blissful and lasts for a long, long time compared to human existence." But it ends. A *deva* (heavenly being) who has used up the good deed that put him there dies like anyone else, and goes where his other deeds take him.

The four unhappy planes. The book describes them: "the hell realms[13] in which there is constant suffering[14]"; "the realm of titans where beings are constantly fighting one another"; "the realm of unhappy ghosts where beings wander about in empty landscapes without food or drink", or wander after their human death "following family and friends or homes they once lived in, unable to communicate with the people they knew, and dependent upon those humans who remember them for food and drink"; and "the animal realm which is all the birds, animals, insects, fish, etc., that we see or don't see about us". The

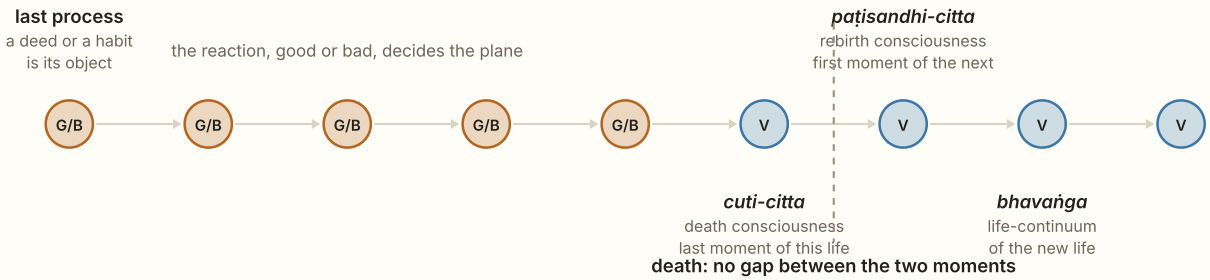
animal realm is the only unhappy plane that human beings can see. Every dog, every ant and every fish is a being that was once somewhere else and will be somewhere else again. “We all pass back and forth through these realms continuously from happy to unhappy and back again, round and round without end.”

No beginning. “The Buddha also explained that there has been no beginning to this wheel, to the round of births, and there will be no end as long as there is ignorance of the true nature of life.” The book quotes the *Saṃyutta Nikāya* (the Grouped Discourses[15]):

> *“A world without end is this round of birth and death. No beginning can be seen of those beings hindered[16] by ignorance, bound by craving[17] running through the round of birth and death. Just as if a man should chop up all of the straws, boughs[18], twigs and leaves in India and piling them together should lay them in a heap, square by square, saying: ‘This is my mother, this is the mother of that mother of mine’,—still unsupplied would be the mother’s mothers of that man. Nay[19], to supply them all, the straw, boughs, twigs and leaves in this India would come to an end and be used up, ere[20] this were done.”*

Every mother had a mother. If a man laid down one twig for each of them, all the twigs in India would be used up first.

The last moment. “In the last thought process before death a deed performed somewhere in the past surfaces (it can be from this life or any other life) and becomes the object[21] of that thought process. If there is no deed strong enough at that moment, it will instead be a habitual[22] thought pattern of some sort that becomes the object of that last thought process.” The mind reacts to that object, and the reaction is *kusala* (good) or *akusala* (bad). “We will be born in a happy realm if it is wholesome[23] or an unhappy realm if it is unwholesome[24].” The book’s example: if someone had killed a living being during this life, and that deed comes up at the last moment, and the mind reacts to it with regret or aversion[25], “that is an unwholesome reaction”.



“The next moment is called birth-consciousness (patisandhi citta) and that is the first moment of life for the new being.”

“The following moment is called death-consciousness[26] (cuti-citta). That is the last moment of life. The next moment is called birth-consciousness (patisandhi citta) and that is the first moment of life for the new being.” There is no gap. If the last process was unwholesome, “then the rebirth is in an unhappy plane, say as a dog. That patisandhi citta will be the moment of conception[27] in the womb[28] of the mother.”

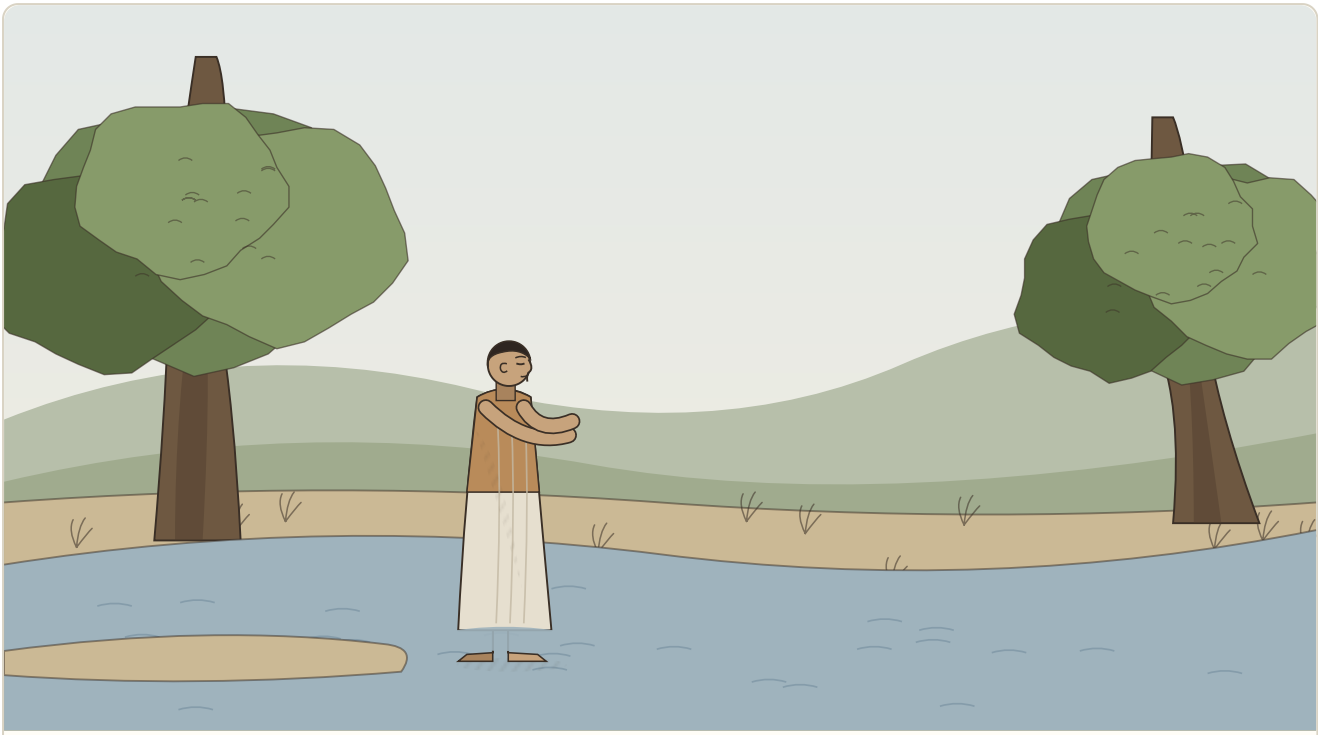
Nobody is in charge. "We have no control over this process. We cannot determine where we will be born next. We cannot arrange things so that at our death the right things will occur to us and we will obtain a happy rebirth. Whatever persons surround us or help us they cannot determine our last thought process. It depends upon deeds in the past what happens to us at death." And not only at death: "It is further deeds that determine our body, the family we are born into, whether we will be wealthy or not, whether we will die at an early age; everything that we experience[29] is because of deeds in the past."

The book says: "You can see then how important an understanding of moral and immoral deeds is. Without this understanding beings wander through life sometimes doing the most atrocious[30] things to each other. All of this happens through ignorance of the true nature of the law of cause and effect." The only thing that can be done about the last moment of this life is done now, by the kind of *citta* (consciousness) that arises[31] in this moment.

HARD WORDS IN THIS CHAPTER

1. **process**: a row of moments that follow one another in order
2. **being**: any living creature: a person, an animal, a heavenly being
3. **morality**: good conduct; not killing, not stealing, not lying and the rest
4. **immoral**: bad conduct; wrong
5. **deed**: something done; an act, good or bad
6. **ignorance**: not knowing; not understanding what is really there
7. **enumerate**: to count up and list one by one
8. **plane**: a world or level where beings live: the human world, the heavens, the animal world and so on
9. **woeful**: full of sorrow; very unhappy
10. **titan**: a kind of being that loves fighting
11. **matter**: the kind of reality that does not know or feel anything, such as hardness, colour or sound
12. **rebirth**: being born again in a new life after this one ends
13. **realm**: a kingdom; here, one of the worlds that beings can be born in
14. **suffering**: pain and trouble; anything that cannot give lasting happiness
15. **discourse**: a talk or sermon; here, one of the Buddha's talks written down
16. **hinder**: to get in the way of; to hold back
17. **craving**: strong wanting; a thirst for something
18. **bough**: a big branch of a tree
19. **nay**: no
20. **ere**: before
21. **object**: the thing that a moment of mind knows: a colour, a sound, a thought
22. **habitual**: done out of habit, again and again
23. **wholesome**: good and healthy for the mind: giving, kindness, patience, understanding
24. **unwholesome**: bad for the mind: wanting, anger, not knowing
25. **aversion**: not liking something and wanting it to go away; anger, even a little
26. **consciousness**: a moment of mind that knows something, such as seeing or hearing
27. **conception**: the very start of a new life inside the mother
28. **womb**: the place inside a mother where a baby grows
29. **experience**: to know, see, hear or feel something; or the knowing itself
30. **atrocious**: very cruel and terrible
31. **arise**: to come up; to begin; to happen

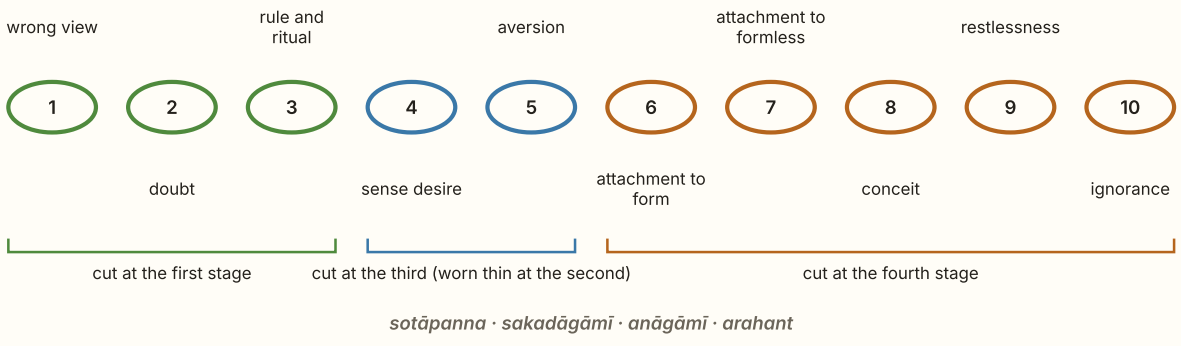
Lesson 8: the four stages of enlightenment



"Streamwinner (sotapanna) means one has entered the stream to final enlightenment"

A way out. The wheel has no beginning, but it has an end for the one who understands. "The process[1] by which one comes to understand the truth is also explained in the Abhidhamma. There are four stages of enlightenment[2]." The book names them: "first the stream-winner, second the once-returner, third the never-returner and fourth the fully-enlightened one". In Pali: *sotāpanna* (stream-enterer), *sakadāgāmī* (once-returner), *anāgāmī* (never-returner) and *arahant* (fully enlightened).

The ten fetters. What holds a being[3] to the wheel is called a *saṃyojana* (fetter[4]), a chain. There are ten, and the four stages are four cuttings of the chain.



"There are then, ten fetters which bind us to the wheel of existence."

Fetter	Pali	Cut at
wrong view[5]	*sakkāya diṭṭhi* (personality belief)	first stage
doubt	*vicikicchā*	first stage
adherence to rule and ritual	*sīlabbata parāmāsa*	first stage
sense desire	*kāma rāga*	third stage (weakened at the second)
aversion[6]	*vyāpāda*	third stage (weakened at the second)
attachment[7] to existence in the form realms[8]	*rūpa rāga*	fourth stage
attachment to existence in the formless realms	*arūpa rāga*	fourth stage
conceit[9]	*māna*	fourth stage
restlessness[10]	*uddhacca*	fourth stage
ignorance[11]	*avijjā*	fourth stage

The first stage. "At the first stage, a being has eliminated[12] the first three fetters which bind one to the wheel of existence." Wrong view is "an incorrect view of the way things are, i.e., that there is a self, that there really are permanent people and things rather than just momentary[13] physical and mental[14] phenomena[15]". Doubt is doubt "about the truth of the Dhamma". Adherence to rule and ritual is the belief "that there is a method or a technique or something which one performs that will lead one to enlightenment". The *sotāpanna* (stream-enterer) has seen for himself that there is only *nāma* (mind) and *rūpa* (matter[16]), so the belief in a self cannot come back, and he cannot believe that any ceremony could have done it for him.

"Streamwinner (sotapanna) means one has entered the stream to final enlightenment and that there are no more conditions[17] to be born in a lower plane[18] than that of a human being." The stream-enterer still has attachment and anger. He can still be born again, but never in the four unhappy planes, and the ancient texts say he will reach the end within seven lives at most.

The dirt on a fingernail. In the *Saṃyutta Nikāya* (the Grouped Discourses[19]) the Buddha once picked up a little dirt on his fingernail and asked the monks[20]: "Which is more: the little bit of dirt on my fingernail, or this great earth?" They answered: "Sir, the great earth is far more. The little bit of dirt on your fingernail is tiny." In the same way, he said, for the *sotāpanna* (stream-enterer) the suffering[21] that is finished is like the great earth, and the suffering that remains, in seven lives at the most, is like the dirt on the fingernail: "what's left is tiny."

The second stage. "A once-returner (sakadagami) lessens his attachment and aversion. He is called once-returner because he can return only once more to the human plane." The next two fetters are not yet cut, only worn thin.

The third stage. "A never-returner (anagami) eliminates two further fetters, these being sense-desire and aversion. He has no more desire for sense-objects[22] and no more dislike for unpleasant things. The never-returner does not return to the human plane again. If he dies as an anagami he is born into a god realm where he attains final enlightenment." Those realms are the five highest *Brahmā* (highest heavenly) planes of fine matter, which the ancient texts call the *Suddhāvāsa* (the Pure Abodes), because only never-returners are born there.

The fourth stage. "The last stage is the fully enlightened one (the arahant). He has eliminated the last five fetters which bind him to the wheel of existence. They are attachment to existence in the form-god realms, attachment to existence in the formless-god realms, conceit, restlessness and ignorance. Because of the first of these two fetters beings are born into the god realms. When they are eliminated there is no more desire for any existence at all." "There are then, ten fetters which bind us to the wheel of existence."

Moments, not people. Each stage is reached at one moment of *lokuttara citta* (consciousness[23] beyond the world), the *magga citta* (path consciousness), which experiences[24] *nibbāna* (the end of all troubles) and cuts the fetters for good. It is followed at once by *phala citta* (fruition[25] consciousness), which also experiences *nibbāna* (the end of all troubles). Lesson 3 counted these among the eighty-nine. After the fourth path moment there is no more *kusala* (good) and no more *akusala* (bad), because there is no more *kamma* (deed[26]) to make. Everything the *arahant* (fully enlightened one) does from then on is *kiriya* (functional[27]).

What happens when an arahant dies? The book asks and answers. "He has eliminated all unwholesome[28] tendencies[29] from his character including the desire to go on being born. Having become enlightened during this life, he will die at the time when his lifespan[30] has expired[31]. Since there is no more desire to go on, when the last moment of life for the arahant finishes it is not followed by another rebirth[32] consciousness. When we die, it is immediately followed by another moment (of the next life); when an arahant dies, that is all. No more experience. No more rebirth. This is called by the Buddha the only true peace."

Not a ladder either. Nobody climbs the four stages by wanting to. The fetters are cut by *paññā* (wisdom) that has seen *nāma* (mind) and *rūpa* (matter) as they are, moment after moment, for a long time. Reading a list of ten fetters cuts none of them. But the first of them, the view that there is a self, is the one that every lesson in this course has been about.

HARD WORDS IN THIS CHAPTER

1. **process**: a row of moments that follow one another in order
2. **enlightenment**: the moment when the truth is seen fully and for good, and the dirt of the mind is cut away
3. **being**: any living creature: a person, an animal, a heavenly being
4. **fetter**: a chain for the feet; here, what keeps a being tied to the round of birth and death
5. **wrong view**: a wrong idea about what is real, such as the idea that there is a lasting self
6. **aversion**: not liking something and wanting it to go away; anger, even a little
7. **attachment**: wanting something and holding on to it; liking that will not let go
8. **realm**: a kingdom; here, one of the worlds that beings can be born in
9. **conceit**: thinking oneself better than others, or worse, or just as good; pride that compares
10. **restlessness**: not being able to be still; a mind that jumps about
11. **ignorance**: not knowing; not understanding what is really there
12. **eliminate**: to get rid of

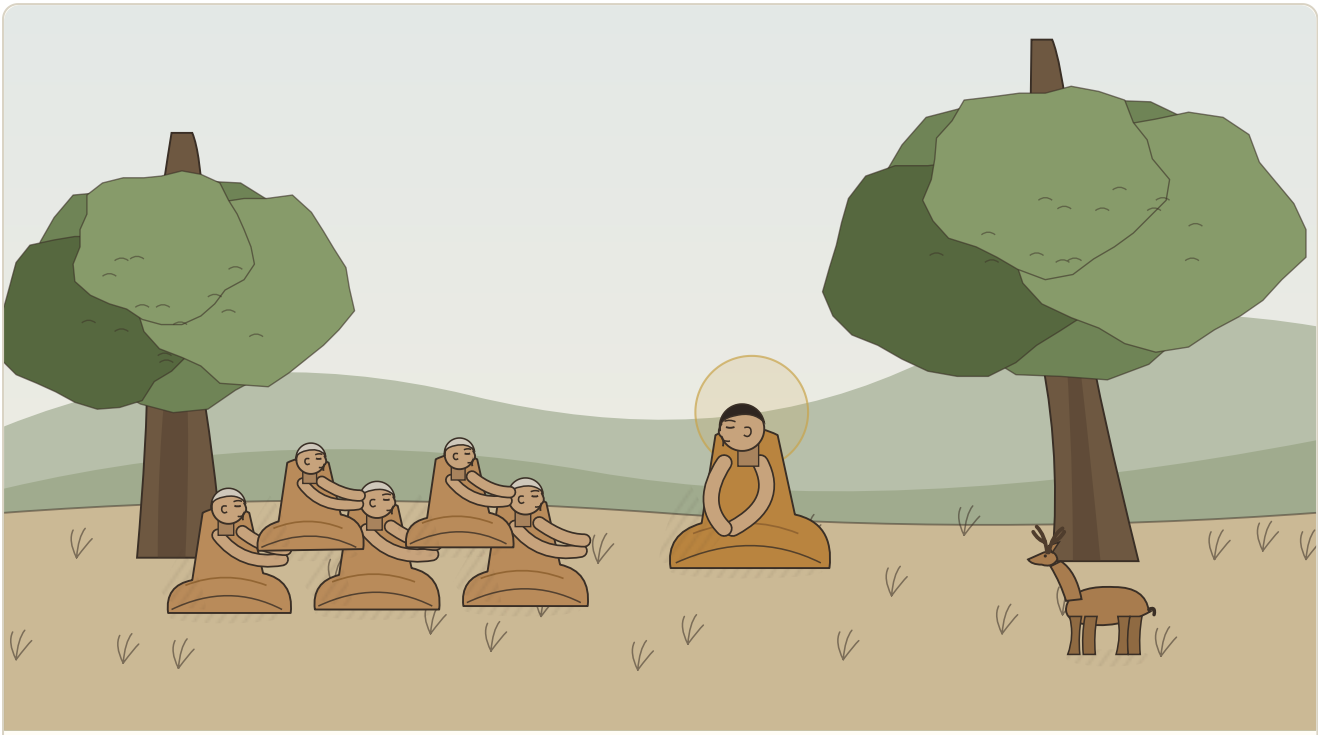
13. **momentary**: lasting only a moment
14. **mental**: to do with the mind
15. **phenomena**: things that happen or appear; here, the realities of mind and matter
16. **matter**: the kind of reality that does not know or feel anything, such as hardness, colour or sound
17. **condition**: something that has to be there before another thing can happen
18. **plane**: a world or level where beings live: the human world, the heavens, the animal world and so on
19. **discourse**: a talk or sermon; here, one of the Buddha's talks written down
20. **monk**: a man who has left home to follow the Buddha's rule of life
21. **suffering**: pain and trouble; anything that cannot give lasting happiness
22. **object**: the thing that a moment of mind knows: a colour, a sound, a thought
23. **consciousness**: a moment of mind that knows something, such as seeing or hearing
24. **experience**: to know, see, hear or feel something; or the knowing itself
25. **fruition**: bearing fruit; here, the moment that comes right after the path moment
26. **deed**: something done; an act, good or bad
27. **functional**: doing a job without being a cause or a result
28. **unwholesome**: bad for the mind: wanting, anger, not knowing
29. **tendency**: a leaning towards doing something; a habit of the mind
30. **lifespan**: the length of a life
31. **expire**: to run out; to come to an end
32. **rebirth**: being born again in a new life after this one ends

Quiz 4 (lessons 7 and 8)

The answers are at the back.

1. How many planes of existence did the Buddha enumerate?
    - (a) 4
    - (b) 10
    - (c) 31
    - (d) 89
2. Name the four woeful planes.
3. What does the book say all 31 planes have in common?
    - (a) they are all pleasant
    - (b) they are all temporary
    - (c) they are all visible
    - (d) they all have the same lifespan
4. In the simile of the sticks and leaves, what would be used up first: the sticks in India, or the man's mothers?
5. Put these in the order they happen at the end of a life.
    - *cuti-citta* (death consciousness), the last moment of this life
    - the mind reacts to it with *kusala* (good) or *akusala* (bad)
    - a past deed, or a habit, becomes the object of the last thought process
    - *paṭisandhi-citta* (rebirth consciousness), the first moment of the next life
6. True or false: with the right friends around, a person can arrange a happy rebirth at the moment of death.
7. Which three fetters are cut at the first stage of enlightenment?
    - (a) sense desire, aversion and conceit
    - (b) wrong view, doubt and adherence to rule and ritual
    - (c) restlessness, ignorance and conceit
    - (d) attachment to form, attachment to the formless and ignorance
8. Why is the *sotāpanna* (stream-enterer) called that, and what can no longer happen to him?
9. The *anāgāmī* (never-returner) has given up:
    - (a) conceit and restlessness
    - (b) sense desire and aversion
    - (c) wrong view and doubt
    - (d) all ten fetters
10. Name the five fetters cut by the *arahant* (fully enlightened one).
11. What happens when an *arahant* (fully enlightened one) dies?
12. True or false: the book says the stages of enlightenment are reached by performing the right ritual.

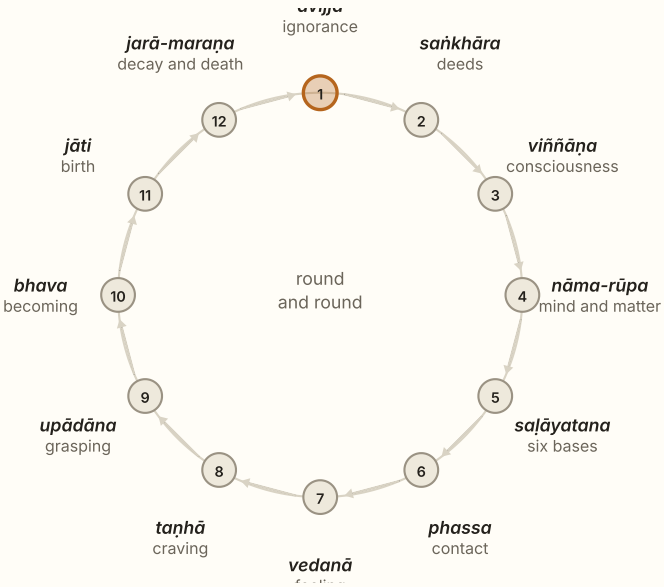
Lesson 9: the chain, the four truths and the three marks



"Koṇḍañña has really understood! Koṇḍañña has really understood!"

The book says: "There are three more aspects which should be discussed—the Law of Dependent Origination[1], the three basic characteristics[2] of existence and the Four Noble Truths."

Dependent origination. *Paṭicca samuppāda* (dependent origination) "is the Buddha's explanation of how states of existence come to be and how they condition[3] each other". The book sets it out as a chain of links:



"We can see then that at the root of it all is ignorance."

1. Dependent on *avijjā* (ignorance[4]) arise[5] *saṅkhāra* (karmic activities, deeds[6])
2. Dependent on *saṅkhāra* (deeds) arises *viññāṇa* (consciousness[7])

3. Dependent on *viññāṇa* (consciousness) arise *nāma-rūpa* (mind and matter[8])
4. Dependent on *nāma-rūpa* (mind and matter) arise *saḷāyatana* (the six-fold bases, the five senses and thinking)
5. Dependent on *saḷāyatana* (the six bases) arises *phassa* (contact)
6. Dependent on *phassa* (contact) arises *vedanā* (feeling)
7. Dependent on *vedanā* (feeling) arises *taṇhā* (craving[9])
8. Dependent on *taṇhā* (craving) arises *upādāna* (grasping[10])
9. Dependent on *upādāna* (grasping) arises *bhava* (becoming)
10. Dependent on *bhava* (becoming) arises *jāti* (birth)
11. Dependent on *jāti* (birth) arise *jarā-maraṇa* (decay and death), sorrow, lamentation[11], pain, grief[12] and despair[13]

"Thus arises the whole mass of suffering[14]." The links are turning all the time. Because of ignorance, deeds are done; because of deeds, a new life begins; with it come mind and matter, the senses, contact, feeling, wanting, grasping, a new existence, birth, old age and death. And then round again.

Seen the other way, the chain is a way out: when ignorance ends, the deeds that make rebirth[15] are not done, and the rest does not arise. "We can see then that at the root of it all is ignorance. That is defined as ignorance of the Four Noble Truths."

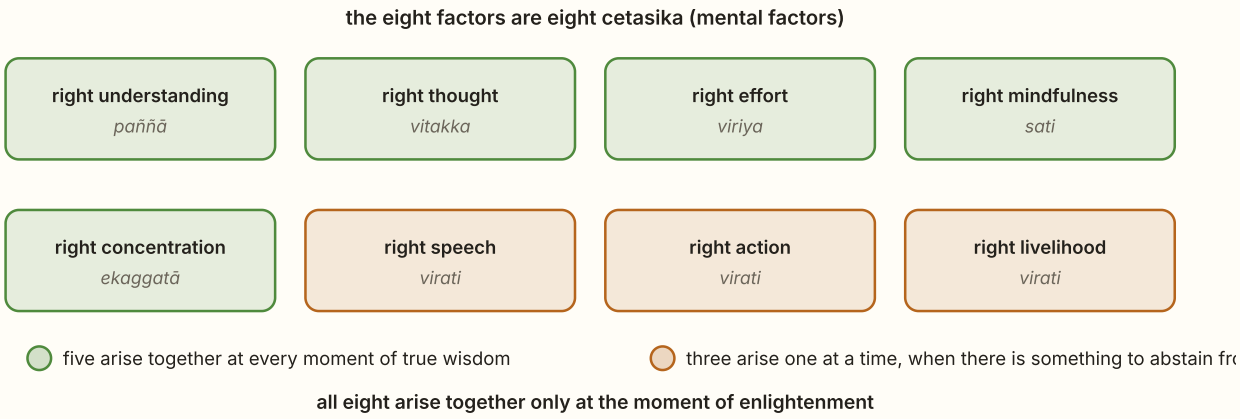
The Four Noble Truths. The Buddha taught them first, in the deer park at Isipatana near Bārāṇasī (Benares), to the five ascetics[16] who had once been his companions. In Pali the four are *dukkha* (suffering), *samudaya* (its origin), *nirodha* (its ending) and *magga* (the path):

1. Life is unsatisfactory[17] or suffering: *dukkha* (suffering).
2. Suffering arises because of craving: *taṇhā* (craving).
3. There is an ending of suffering, which is *nibbāna* (the end of all troubles), the stopping of craving.
4. The way leading to the ending of suffering is the *ariya aṭṭhaṅgika magga* (the Noble Eightfold Path).

The first sermon. The discourse[18] in which the Buddha taught these truths is the *Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta* (the Discourse on Setting the Wheel of the Teaching in Motion). Two months after his enlightenment[19] he walked to Isipatana, where the five ascetics were staying. They had left him when he gave up starving himself, and they agreed not to rise for him. But as he came near they could not keep to it: one took his bowl, one made a seat, one brought water for his feet. He told them that there are two extremes that should not be followed: indulgence[20] in sensual[21] pleasures, and tormenting[22] oneself. Between them lies the middle way, the Eightfold Path. Then he taught the Four Noble Truths. As he spoke, the eldest of the five, Koṇḍañña, saw the truth for himself: "Everything that is liable[23] to arise is liable to cease[24]." The Buddha said: "Koṇḍañña has really understood! Koṇḍañña has really understood!" Koṇḍañña had become a *sotāpanna* (stream-enterer), the first of the Buddha's disciples[25] to do so.

"When one does not understand these truths directly one is subject to continual rebirth in the wheel of existence." The eight factors of the path are: right understanding, right thought, right speech, right action, right livelihood[26], right effort, right mindfulness[27] and right concentration[28].

The path is made of moments. The Eightfold Path "is often taught as a 'path' which one follows by developing each of the factors piece by piece until there are all perfected. In the Abhidhamma it is made clear that the Eightfold Path is in fact only momentary[29] phenomena[30] like everything else. The Eightfold Path is not a 'whole path' which one follows, but at the moment that a wholesome[31] moment of wisdom (the wisdom that understands the true nature of things) arises then it is accompanied by the Eightfold Path factors as mental factors[32] (cetasikas)." The eight factors are eight *cetasika* (mental[33] factors) from Lesson 4. Right understanding is *paññā* (wisdom). Right thought is *vitakka* (applied thought). Right effort is *viriya* (effort). Right mindfulness is *sati* (mindfulness). Right concentration is *ekaggatā* (concentration). Right speech, right action and right livelihood are the three *virati* (abstinences[34]).



"Five of these factors accompany every moment of true wisdom. The whole eight occur together only at the moments of enlightenment."

"Five of these factors accompany every moment of true wisdom. The whole eight occur together only at the moments of enlightenment." The five are understanding, thought, effort, mindfulness and concentration. The three abstinences arise one at a time, when there is something to abstain from. Only at the moment of *magga citta* (path consciousness), when *nibbāna* (the end of all troubles) is experienced[35], do all eight arise at once. So nobody walks the path. The path arises for one moment, falls away[36], and arises again when the conditions are there.

The three marks. "Finally, the Buddha also explained that there are three things characterising all elements[37] of existence." Every *citta* (consciousness), every *cetasika* (mental factor) and every *rūpa* (matter) has these three marks:

- *dukkha* (unsatisfactory): "there is no lasting satisfaction in them"
- *anicca* (impermanent[38]): "they do not last even for a moment"
- *anattā* (non-self[39]): "there is not a lasting person, self or something in anything, they are all empty of self"

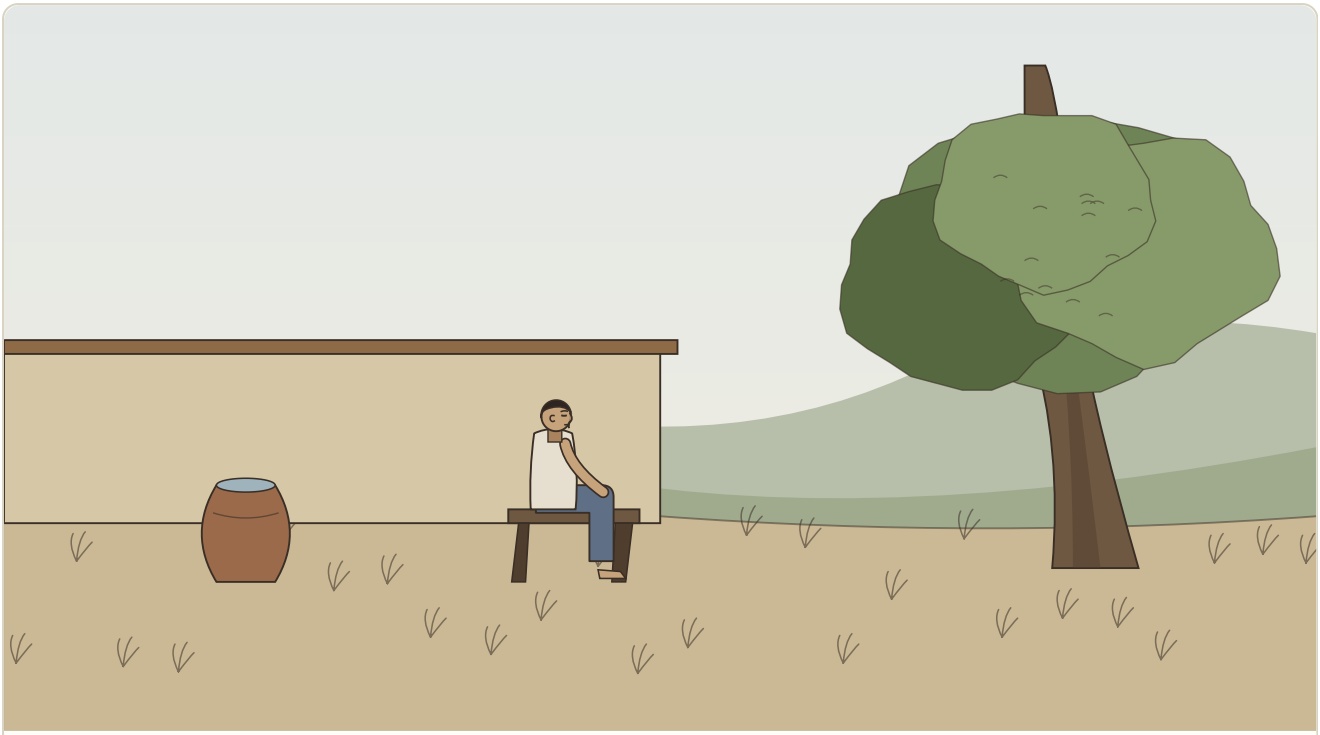
What does not last cannot give lasting satisfaction, and what does not last and cannot satisfy cannot be anyone's self. The ancient texts call these the *tilakkhaṇa* (the three characteristics). The chariot[40], the moments, the eighty-nine, the fifty-two, the twenty-eight, the seed and the fruit, the wheel and the fetters[41] all point at the same three facts.

One root. Ignorance begins the chain; wisdom ends it. The next lesson asks where that wisdom has to begin.

HARD WORDS IN THIS CHAPTER

1. **origin**: where something comes from; its beginning
2. **characteristic**: the mark by which something is known; what is special about it
3. **condition**: something that has to be there before another thing can happen
4. **ignorance**: not knowing; not understanding what is really there
5. **arise**: to come up; to begin; to happen
6. **deed**: something done; an act, good or bad
7. **consciousness**: a moment of mind that knows something, such as seeing or hearing
8. **matter**: the kind of reality that does not know or feel anything, such as hardness, colour or sound
9. **craving**: strong wanting; a thirst for something
10. **grasping**: holding on tightly; clinging
11. **lamentation**: crying out in sorrow
12. **grief**: deep sadness, as when someone dies
13. **despair**: losing all hope
14. **suffering**: pain and trouble; anything that cannot give lasting happiness
15. **rebirth**: being born again in a new life after this one ends
16. **ascetic**: a person who gives up home and comfort to live simply and seek the truth; or that hard way of living
17. **unsatisfactory**: never quite good enough; not able to give lasting happiness
18. **discourse**: a talk or sermon; here, one of the Buddha's talks written down
19. **enlightenment**: the moment when the truth is seen fully and for good, and the dirt of the mind is cut away
20. **indulge**: to give in to something one enjoys, too much
21. **sensual**: to do with the pleasures of the senses: nice sights, sounds, tastes and so on
22. **torment**: to cause great pain to
23. **liable**: likely
24. **cessation**: stopping; coming to an end
25. **disciple**: a pupil; someone who follows a teacher
26. **livelihood**: the way a person earns a living
27. **mindfulness**: noticing what is really there right now, without forgetting
28. **concentration**: keeping the mind on one thing
29. **momentary**: lasting only a moment
30. **phenomena**: things that happen or appear; here, the realities of mind and matter
31. **wholesome**: good and healthy for the mind: giving, kindness, patience, understanding
32. **mental factor**: something that goes along with each moment of mind and does its own small job, such as feeling or remembering
33. **mental**: to do with the mind
34. **abstain**: to hold back from doing something, such as lying
35. **experience**: to know, see, hear or feel something; or the knowing itself
36. **fall away**: to end; to stop; to be gone
37. **element**: one of the basic parts that everything is made of
38. **impermanent**: not lasting; passing away
39. **non-self**: not a self; not a person; not anyone's
40. **chariot**: a cart with two wheels pulled by horses, used in old times for war and travel
41. **fetter**: a chain for the feet; here, what keeps a being tied to the round of birth and death

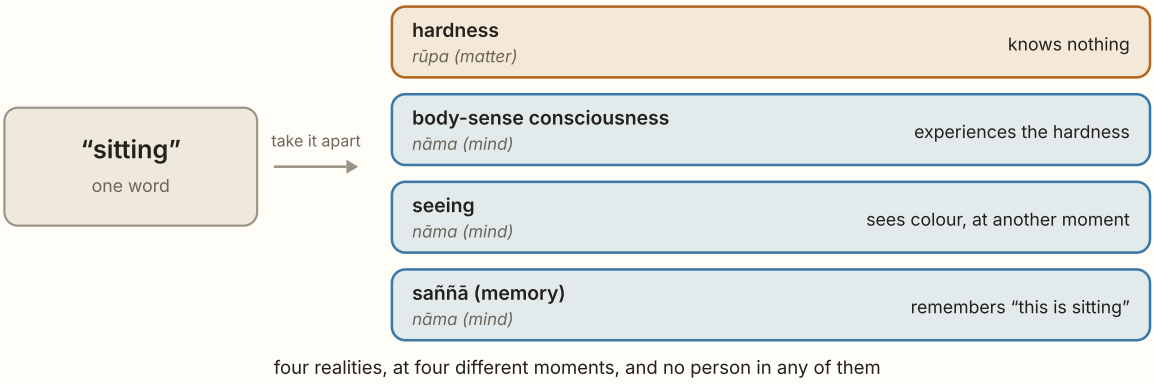
Lesson 10: what is happening right now?



"When we sit down how do we know that we are sitting?"

The point of the lists. The book ends by asking the question any reader will have been asking. "You may wonder what is the point of all these classifications[1]. Are they of any use to one in coming to understanding the truth of the way things are?" Its answer: "When the Abhidhamma enumerates[2] lists of types of consciousness[3] and lists of types of matter[4] this is so that one can understand that this is all that there really is right now." Right now, in this moment, there is nothing but some of the eighty-nine, some of the fifty-two and some of the twenty-eight.

Sitting. The book takes the plainest thing it can find. "We sit and we talk and we think and we move about but we do not realise that our sitting and talking and thinking, etc., are in fact conditioned[5] by many different things. When we sit down how do we know that we are sitting? You may say, 'Well it's obvious, isn't it?' But 'sitting' is known because of different experiences[6] through the body-sense[7] and the eye perhaps, and we remember that these experiences when occurring all together are conventionally[8] known as sitting."



"So in reality no 'person' exists who is 'sitting' on a 'chair'."

"It is, in fact, a type of (body-sense) consciousness which experiences hardness through the body, seeing which sees and memory which remembers what we are doing. Body-sense, seeing and memory are all types of nama which are conditioned. They are each different and each have different functions[9]. Hardness is a type of rupa (matter). It cannot know anything about anything. Hardness is not a seat. 'Seat' or 'chair' are conventional labels we give to other sets of experience through different senses. None of these experiences is a person sitting. Each is different. Each experience occurs at a different moment. So in reality[10] no 'person' exists who is 'sitting' on a 'chair'. There are just different realities occurring one after another through different senses."

So, in the moment that is called "sitting", there is:

- hardness, which is *rūpa* (matter) and knows nothing;
- the body-sense *citta* (consciousness) that experiences the hardness, which is *nāma* (mind);
- seeing, which sees colour, another *nāma* (mind) at another moment;
- *saññā* (memory), the *cetasika* (mental factor[11]) that remembers "this is sitting", at yet another moment.

Four different realities, at different moments. The word "sitting" is the box they are put in. The word "I" is the box the box is put in.

Pain. "This may still not seem clear, but perhaps if we apply this knowledge to all of our life, we can see that pain, for example, is just unpleasant result[12] (of deeds[13] in the past), that the aversion[14] to pain is just nama, that the unpleasant feeling when there is pain is also just nama." When a child falls and scrapes a knee, the sting is *vipāka* (result), and cannot be helped; the "I hate this" that follows is not result, and can be known as *dosa* (anger), arising[15] and falling away[16].

Insults. "When people insult us, it is just sound appearing through the ear." Hearing the sound is *vipāka* (result). The sound is *rūpa* (matter); it knows nothing. The meaning is put together afterwards by thinking, and the hurt is *dosa* (anger) arising in a later moment. "It is only when we see and hear 'things' which we don't like that we have all our problems, worries, strife[17] and woe[18]."

No person in them. The book's last teaching sentence: "To understand Abhidhamma is to understand that there is just seeing, hearing, thinking, touching, tasting, etc., but no person in them. This knowledge as it develops, ultimately[19] brings us release[20] from this unsatisfactory[21] wheel of existence."

Every lesson has been about this sentence. Lesson 2 said that seeing is *nāma* (mind) and colour is *rūpa* (matter). Lesson 3 said that seeing is a *vipāka citta* (result consciousness), one of eighty-nine. Lesson 4 said that it arises with seven *cetasika* (mental[22] factors). Lesson 5 said that the eye-sense and the colour are among the twenty-eight kinds of *rūpa* (matter). Lesson 6 said that the seeing is the fruit of a deed. Lesson 7 said that this body and this life are the fruit of deeds too. Lesson 8 said that the view of a self in all this is the first fetter[23] to be cut. Lesson 9 said that seeing is *anicca* (impermanent[24]), *dukkha* (unsatisfactory) and *anattā* (non-self[25]).

What the Abhidhamma is for. The preface to the book says: "A study of the Abhidhamma can be of immense value to us in coming to terms with the nature of life and understanding it in the way of momentary[26] events." And: "As we understand more and more the Buddha's teaching, we will be more kind, more considerate[27] and more harmless (in the true sense of causing no harm) to all our fellow beings[28]."

The last word. The book closes with a verse from the *Visuddhimagga* (the Path of Purity[29]) by Buddhaghosa, which it calls "the greatest written summary of the Theravadin teachings in existence today":

> *As long as a man is vague[30] about the world,*
> *About its origin[31], about its ceasing[32],*
> *About the means that lead to its cessation,*
> *So long he cannot recognise the truths.*

The world is this moment of *nāma* (mind) and *rūpa* (matter). Its origin is craving[33] and ignorance[34]. Its ceasing is *nibbāna* (the end of all troubles). The means is the path, arising moment by moment.

HARD WORDS IN THIS CHAPTER

1. **classification**: sorting things into kinds
2. **enumerate**: to count up and list one by one
3. **consciousness**: a moment of mind that knows something, such as seeing or hearing
4. **matter**: the kind of reality that does not know or feel anything, such as hardness, colour or sound
5. **conditioned**: made to happen by other things; it could not come up on its own
6. **experience**: to know, see, hear or feel something; or the knowing itself
7. **bodysense**: the sense of touch, all over the body
8. **conventional**: the ordinary everyday way of talking, as when a pile of parts is called a chariot
9. **function**: the job that something does
10. **reality**: something that is really there, not only a name or an idea
11. **mental factor**: something that goes along with each moment of mind and does its own small job, such as feeling or remembering
12. **result**: what comes later from a deed done before, as fruit comes from a seed
13. **deed**: something done; an act, good or bad
14. **aversion**: not liking something and wanting it to go away; anger, even a little
15. **arise**: to come up; to begin; to happen
16. **fall away**: to end; to stop; to be gone
17. **strife**: fighting and quarrelling
18. **woe**: sorrow and trouble
19. **ultimate**: the deepest and most real; what is really there when all the names are taken away
20. **liberation**: being set free
21. **unsatisfactory**: never quite good enough; not able to give lasting happiness
22. **mental**: to do with the mind
23. **fetter**: a chain for the feet; here, what keeps a being tied to the round of birth and death
24. **impermanent**: not lasting; passing away
25. **non-self**: not a self; not a person; not anyone's

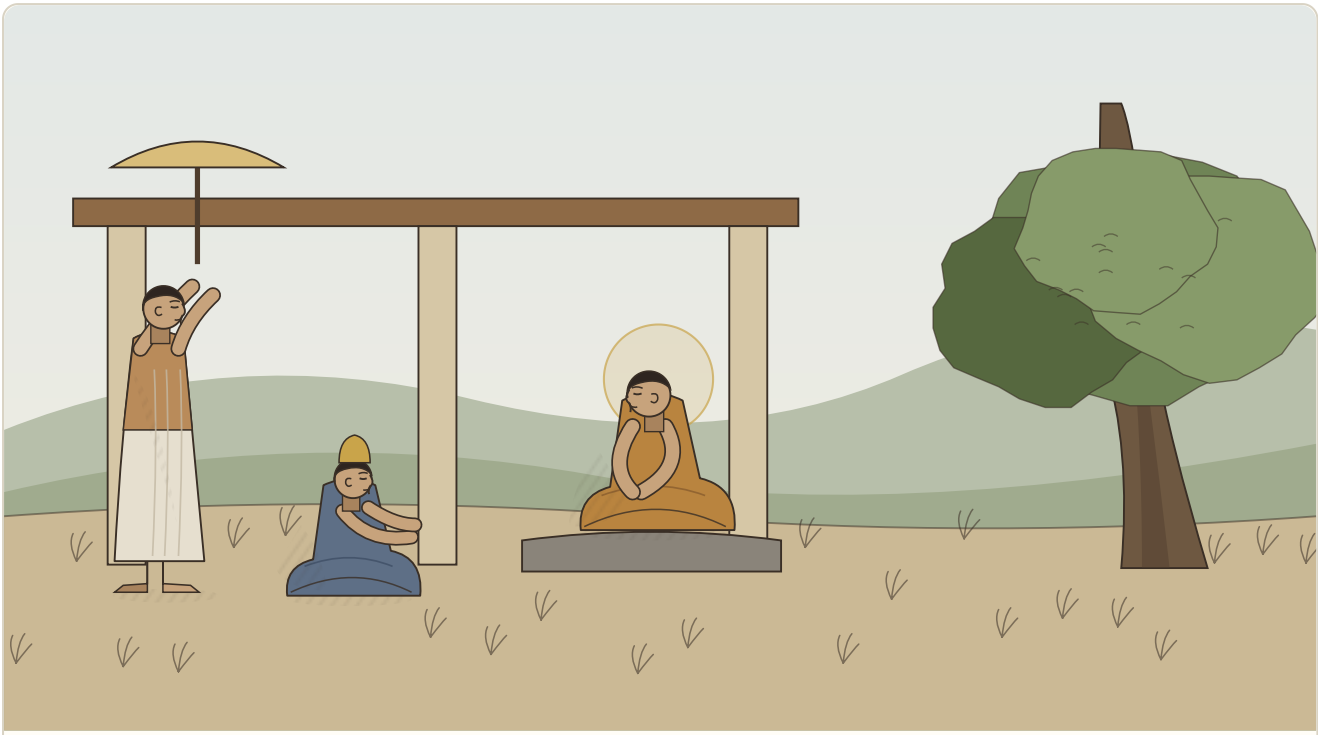
26. **momentary**: lasting only a moment
27. **considerate**: thinking of other people's feelings
28. **being**: any living creature: a person, an animal, a heavenly being
29. **purify**: to make clean; cleanness
30. **vague**: not clear; hazy
31. **origin**: where something comes from; its beginning
32. **cessation**: stopping; coming to an end
33. **craving**: strong wanting; a thirst for something
34. **ignorance**: not knowing; not understanding what is really there

Quiz 5 (lessons 9 and 10)

The answers are at the back.

1. In *paṭicca samuppāda* (dependent origination), what is at the root of the whole chain?
    - (a) birth
    - (b) craving
    - (c) ignorance
    - (d) contact
2. Put these four links in the order they come in the chain.
    - *taṇhā* (craving)
    - *vedanā* (feeling)
    - *phassa* (contact)
    - *upādāna* (grasping)
3. State the Four Noble Truths.
4. According to the Abhidhamma, what is the Eightfold Path?
    - (a) a road that one walks step by step over many years
    - (b) eight mental factors that arise together in a moment of wisdom
    - (c) eight books
    - (d) eight rules for monks
5. How many path factors arise with every moment of true wisdom, and when do all eight arise together?
6. Name the three marks of all conditioned things, in Pali and English.
7. When someone is sitting, what does the book say is really there?
    - (a) a person on a chair
    - (b) body-sense consciousness experiencing hardness, seeing, and memory, each at a different moment
    - (c) a chair and a seat
    - (d) nothing at all
8. True or false: the book says hardness is a seat.
9. When someone is insulted, what is really happening, according to the book?
10. Finish the sentence: “To understand Abhidhamma is to understand that there is just seeing, hearing, thinking, touching, tasting, etc., but …”
11. The closing verse says a man cannot recognise the truths as long as he is “vague about” four things. Which four?
    - (a) the past, the present, the future and himself
    - (b) the world, its origin, its ceasing and the means to its cessation
    - (c) earth, water, fire and wind
    - (d) seeing, hearing, smelling and tasting

Lesson 11: no one is master



"Greed, hate, and delusion:—these three make for trouble, for suffering, for distress."

The second essay in the book is by Nina van Gorkom, and it is called *Abhidhamma and Practice*. The first essay explained what the Abhidhamma says. The second asks what difference it makes.

Three things. The essay opens with a question: "What is the cause of all misery and sorrow in the world?" It answers with a discourse[1] from the *Saṃyutta Nikāya* (the Grouped Discourses, called the Kindred Sayings in the translation it uses), in which King Pasenadi of Kosala asked the Buddha:

> *"How many kinds of things, lord, that happen in the world, make for trouble, for suffering[2], for distress?"*

The Buddha answered:

> *"Three things, sire, happen of that nature. What are the three? Greed, hate, and delusion[3]:—these three make for trouble, for suffering, for distress."*

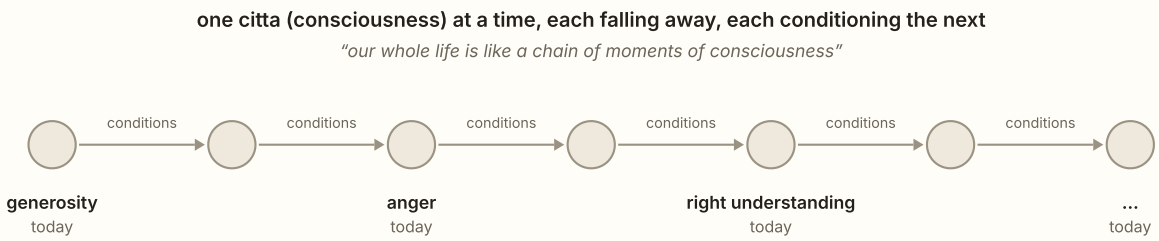
Greed is *lobha* (attachment[4]); hate is *dosa* (anger); delusion is *moha* (ignorance[5]): the three roots of Lesson 3. "In the Buddha's time defilements[6] were the cause of all sorrow and suffering and this is also true for today. It is true for all times. Only those who are perfected have no more sorrow and suffering."

The solution. "The Buddha taught the solution to all problems: the eradication[7] of all unwholesomeness[8] through the development of right understanding; right understanding of all phenomena[9] of our life." Is it selfish to be busy with one's own defilements? And is it even possible? "We cannot eradicate the defilements of others, 'we' cannot even eradicate our own defilements. But when right understanding has been developed, it is right understanding which can gradually eradicate defilements. But this may take many lives." Nobody does it; *paññā* (wisdom) does it. And as for selfishness: "We usually seek only

ourselves and we serve our own interests. How could we then really serve other people? Detachment[10] from ‘self’ is only possible through right understanding of the phenomena of our life. Through right understanding there will be less unwholesomeness in life and more wholesomeness[11], such as loving-kindness[12] and compassion[13].”

Where is the mind? “We are attached to the idea of ‘my mind’, but where is it? Is it thinking? But thinking is never the same, we think now of this, now of that. There is thinking now, but it is always changing. Is feeling something which lasts? Feeling is sometimes pleasant, sometimes unpleasant, and sometimes there is indifferent[14] feeling. Each moment feeling is different. There is no mind, there are only ever-changing mental[15] phenomena which do not belong to a self.”

Love is real. This does not mean that nothing matters. “Love is real, but it falls away[16] immediately, and it does not belong to a self who could be master of it. We can have the intention[17] to be kind, but we cannot force ourselves to kindness. When things are not the way we want them to be we may become angry, in spite of ourselves, as we say. This shows us that phenomena are anatta, not self. Anger is real, but it falls away immediately. Love, hate, wisdom, generosity[18], all these things are real, but there is no self which could be master of them, they are anatta.” Everybody knows the experience[19] of meaning to be kind and finding anger there instead. If there were a master, the master would choose kindness every time.

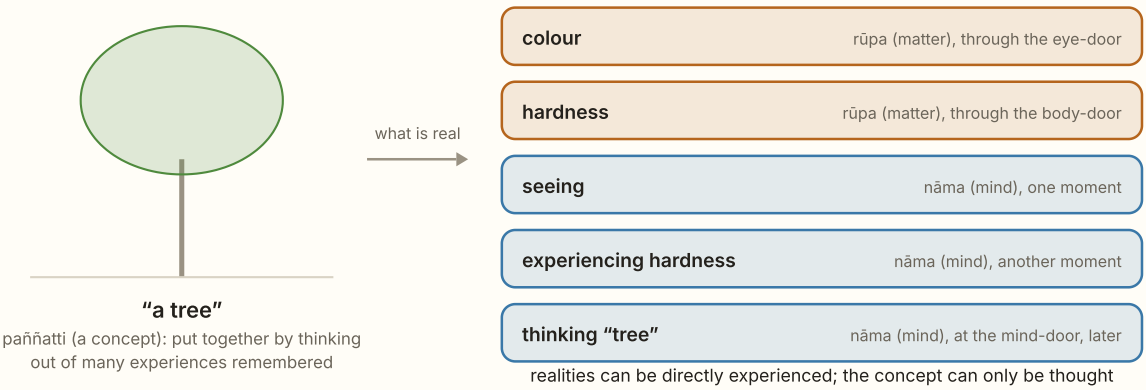


“Thus our whole life is like a chain of moments of consciousness.”

Character. “Does not everybody have his own personality? There is nothing lasting in a man, not even what we call his character.” What there is, the essay says, is a chain. “There is only one moment of consciousness[20] (citta) at a time, and it falls away immediately after it has arisen[21], but it is succeeded by[22] a next moment. Thus our whole life is like a chain of moments of consciousness. Each moment of consciousness which falls away conditions[23] the next moment of consciousness and thus it is possible that our good and bad moments today condition our inclinations[24] in the future. Generosity today or anger today conditions generosity or anger in the future. A moment of right understanding now conditions right understanding in the future, and thus it is possible to develop wisdom.” Every moment hands something on to the next. “Although each moment falls away we can still speak of an ‘accumulation[25]’ of experiences in each moment of consciousness, and we can call this character.”

Not estranged. “We do not become estranged[26] from life and from our fellow-men when we see both ourselves and others as nama and rupa which are impermanent[27] and not self.” And: “When there is less clinging[28] to the concept[29] of self we will be able to act with more unselfishness[30] and thus we can be of more help to others.”

Seeing sees only the visible. "We think that we see a person but seeing sees only what appears through the eyes: the visible. A person could not contact the eye-sense. When we pay attention to the shape and form of something there is no seeing, but thinking." And: "Seeing is not thinking. Seeing sees and it does not think. When we close our eyes we may think of many things but we cannot see. When we open our eyes something appears which did not appear when our eyes were closed. There is seeing, and seeing sees visible object[31]. Seeing does not see a man or a tree." The same is true of touch: "The hardness which is experienced is not a body, it is only hardness, a rupa which is experienced through the body-sense[32] and it falls away again, although we do not realize it."



"Person, animal, tree or house are not paramattha dhammas, they are concepts."

Realities and concepts. Things like "person, animal, tree or house are not paramattha dhammas, they are concepts." A *paññatti* (concept) is an idea put together by thinking: "We form up concepts because of a combination of many different experiences which we remember." Colour is a reality[33]; "tree" is a concept. Hardness is a reality; "chair" is a concept. The realities "can be directly experienced by everybody, without there being the need to think about them. We do not have to think of sound or hardness in order to experience them." Concepts can only be thought. This does not mean that thinking is wrong: "We should not try to avoid thinking of people or things, thinking is a reality, it arises. However, we should know that the concepts which are objects of our thinking are not realities."

Blame. "When there is no right understanding of nama and rupa we will only have a superficial[34] knowledge of both ourselves and others. We will have a wrong understanding of cause and effect in life. Don't we blame others for our own unhappiness? The real cause of unhappiness is within ourselves." When a boy is unhappy because his sister took the last mango, the mango and the sister are not the cause. The cause is *lobha* (attachment) and *dosa* (anger), which arose in him, and which will arise again at the next mango unless *paññā* (wisdom) comes to know them. "Right understanding of the different namas and rupas which appear is the only way to have less defilements and thus to have less sorrow in life."

HARD WORDS IN THIS CHAPTER

1. **discourse**: a talk or sermon; here, one of the Buddha's talks written down
2. **suffering**: pain and trouble; anything that cannot give lasting happiness
3. **delusion**: being fooled; not seeing things as they are
4. **attachment**: wanting something and holding on to it; liking that will not let go

5. **ignorance**: not knowing; not understanding what is really there
6. **defilement**: something that makes the mind dirty: wanting, anger, not knowing and the rest
7. **eradicate**: to root out completely, so that it can never come back
8. **unwholesome**: bad for the mind: wanting, anger, not knowing
9. **phenomena**: things that happen or appear; here, the realities of mind and matter
10. **detachment**: not holding on; letting go
11. **wholesome**: good and healthy for the mind: giving, kindness, patience, understanding
12. **loving-kindness**: wishing others well; friendliness to everyone
13. **compassion**: wanting to help someone who is suffering
14. **indifferent**: neither pleasant nor unpleasant; in the middle
15. **mental**: to do with the mind
16. **fall away**: to end; to stop; to be gone
17. **intention**: what the mind means to do; the mind's choosing
18. **generosity**: giving freely and gladly
19. **experience**: to know, see, hear or feel something; or the knowing itself
20. **consciousness**: a moment of mind that knows something, such as seeing or hearing
21. **arise**: to come up; to begin; to happen
22. **succeeded by**: followed by; coming next
23. **condition**: something that has to be there before another thing can happen
24. **inclination**: a leaning towards something; what one tends to do
25. **accumulate**: to gather up bit by bit, so that there is more and more of it
26. **estranged**: cut off from; made a stranger to
27. **impermanent**: not lasting; passing away
28. **clinging**: holding on tightly; not wanting to let go
29. **concept**: an idea put together by thinking, such as 'tree' or 'person'; it cannot be seen or touched by itself
30. **unselfish**: thinking of others, not of oneself
31. **object**: the thing that a moment of mind knows: a colour, a sound, a thought
32. **bodysense**: the sense of touch, all over the body
33. **reality**: something that is really there, not only a name or an idea
34. **superficial**: only on the surface; shallow

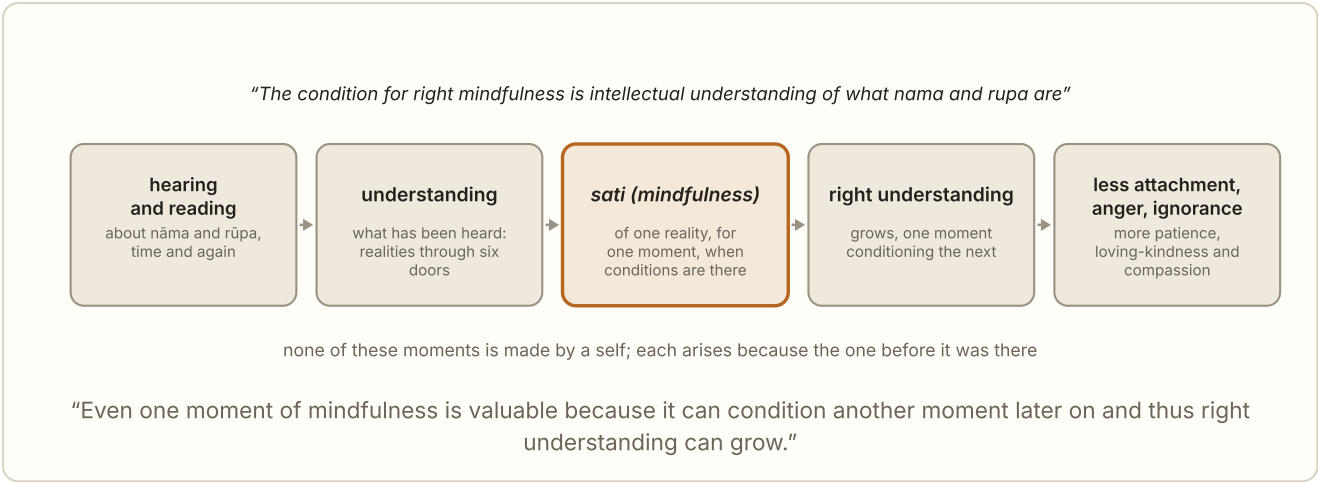
Lesson 12: study with mindfulness



"What appears through the body-sense? Not a person, not my husband."

What the practice is. The second half of Nina van Gorkom's essay is about *vipassanā* (insight[1]): "The development of insight is a kind of study of nama and rupa through the direct experience[2] of them." Not study in a book, though the book comes first, but study at the moment a reality[3] appears. "Namas and rupas which appear one at a time should be 'studied' with mindfulness[4], but each moment of study is extremely short, since mindfulness does not last, it falls away[5]. However, gradually a clearer understanding of realities can be accumulated[6]." The objects[7] of this study are "nama and rupa", "not people, animals or things". "Wherever we are there are in reality only nama and rupa, such as seeing, hearing, the visible object, sound or hardness."

What mindfulness is. *Sati* (mindfulness) is one of the nineteen beautiful mental factors[8] in Lesson 4. "Mindfulness (sati) is nama which arises[9] with a wholesome[10] moment of consciousness[11]. We cannot induce mindfulness whenever we want it, but it can arise when there are the appropriate conditions[12]. All namas and rupas in our life arise only when there are the appropriate conditions, not because of our will." So there is no method of making *sati* (mindfulness) happen. There is only the question of its conditions.



Its condition. "The condition for right mindfulness is intellectual[13] understanding of what nama and rupa are: realities which appear through the six doorways." That is what this course has been for. "When we read in the Buddhist scriptures[14] time and again about the realities which appear through the six doors or we listen to talks about nama and rupa, and we understand what we read or what we hear, then the intellectual understanding can condition the arising of mindfulness. Even one moment of mindfulness is valuable because it can condition another moment later on and thus right understanding can grow." The essay calls this "the highest form of wholesomeness", because "it is the only way to eradicate[15] attachment[16], aversion[17] and ignorance[18]".

What it is not. Many people think that mindfulness means doing everything slowly and carefully, with attention to what the hands and feet are doing. The essay says this is not it. "When one believes that one does all one's actions in a day with thoughtfulness but there is no awareness[19] of nama and rupa, it is not the development of insight. When one, for example, follows what one's hands and feet are doing in a day one does not learn anything about nama and rupa, about what is real, about impermanence[20]." Hands and feet are concepts[21]. What is real when the hand moves is hardness, motion, the body-consciousness that experiences them, and the *citta* (consciousness) that moves them.

Doing everything as usual. "In the development of insight we do everything as usual, but in our daily life there can be mindfulness of a nama or a rupa, a moment of 'study with mindfulness', study through the practice." The essay gives an example from its author's own life:

> *"When my husband takes my hand, there is, as we say, a 'human contact'. What are the realities? There is attachment and this is real, we do not have to try to suppress it. There can, in a very natural way, be study with mindfulness of a nama or a rupa. What appears through the body-sense[22]? Not a person, not my husband. Heat or cold, hardness or softness can appear through the body-sense. We do not have to think about it, it can be directly experienced. Through mindfulness we can prove that no person is experienced through the body-sense, that a person does not exist. There is no person, only different namas and rupas appearing one at a time, and they do not stay."*

The essay does not say that the attachment is wrong and must be stopped. "There is attachment and this is real, we do not have to try to suppress it." The practice is not to change what arises, but to know it. And: "Clinging[23] to people brings sorrow; eventually I will have to take leave from my husband, nothing is permanent."

Kamma, again. With more understanding, "we will have a different view of the events of our life. We like to make plans but often things do not happen the way we would like them to. Our good and bad deeds[24] (kamma) are the causes in our life which bring their results[25] in the form of pleasant and unpleasant experiences. When we understand that our life is nama and rupa which arise because of their own conditions, not because of our will, we will be less attached to pleasant results and less inclined[26] to blame others for unpleasant things we experience. There are only nama and rupa and we are not master of them."

For others too. The essay's last sentences answer the question it began with. "Through the development of insight we will become more patient, we will have more loving-kindness[27] and compassion[28]. Thus, the development of insight is to the benefit of other people as well."

The goal. The appendix to the book, after listing all the conditioned[29] realities, ends with the one that is not conditioned. "There is one type of unconditioned[30] reality and that is called nibbana (in Sanskrit, nirvana). Nibbana is described as the 'deathless[31]', the 'cool', the 'incomparable', the 'peaceful'. It is the end of craving[32], the goal of the Buddha's teachings." Lesson 2 said that *nibbāna* (the end of all troubles) cannot be understood by reading about it. But the road to it begins with hearing what *nāma* (mind) and *rūpa* (matter[33]) are, goes on with understanding what has been heard, and continues, one short moment at a time, with *sati* (mindfulness) of the reality that is appearing right now.

HARD WORDS IN THIS CHAPTER

1. **insight**: seeing into something; here, seeing clearly for oneself that there is only mind and matter
2. **experience**: to know, see, hear or feel something; or the knowing itself
3. **reality**: something that is really there, not only a name or an idea
4. **mindfulness**: noticing what is really there right now, without forgetting
5. **fall away**: to end; to stop; to be gone
6. **accumulate**: to gather up bit by bit, so that there is more and more of it
7. **object**: the thing that a moment of mind knows: a colour, a sound, a thought
8. **mental factor**: something that goes along with each moment of mind and does its own small job, such as feeling or remembering
9. **arise**: to come up; to begin; to happen
10. **wholesome**: good and healthy for the mind: giving, kindness, patience, understanding
11. **consciousness**: a moment of mind that knows something, such as seeing or hearing
12. **condition**: something that has to be there before another thing can happen
13. **intellectual**: to do with thinking and understanding by the mind, not with seeing for oneself
14. **scripture**: holy writings
15. **eradicate**: to root out completely, so that it can never come back
16. **attachment**: wanting something and holding on to it; liking that will not let go
17. **aversion**: not liking something and wanting it to go away; anger, even a little
18. **ignorance**: not knowing; not understanding what is really there
19. **awareness**: noticing what is really there right now; another word for mindfulness
20. **impermanent**: not lasting; passing away
21. **concept**: an idea put together by thinking, such as 'tree' or 'person'; it cannot be seen or touched by itself
22. **bodysense**: the sense of touch, all over the body
23. **clinging**: holding on tightly; not wanting to let go
24. **deed**: something done; an act, good or bad
25. **result**: what comes later from a deed done before, as fruit comes from a seed
26. **inclination**: a leaning towards something; what one tends to do
27. **loving-kindness**: wishing others well; friendliness to everyone
28. **compassion**: wanting to help someone who is suffering
29. **conditioned**: made to happen by other things; it could not come up on its own
30. **unconditioned**: not made by anything; not depending on causes

31. **deathless**: without death; never dying
32. **craving**: strong wanting; a thirst for something
33. **matter**: the kind of reality that does not know or feel anything, such as hardness, colour or sound

Quiz 6 (lessons 11 and 12)

The answers are at the back.

1. King Pasenadi asked the Buddha how many kinds of things make for trouble, suffering and distress. What was the answer?
    - (a) one: ignorance
    - (b) three: greed, hate and delusion
    - (c) ten: the ten fetters
    - (d) eighty-nine
2. Who or what can eradicate defilements, according to the essay?
3. True or false: the essay says that because love falls away at once, love is not real.
4. What does the essay say shows that phenomena are *anattā* (not self)?
5. What does the essay say character really is?
    - (a) a lasting thing in a person
    - (b) an accumulation of experiences handed on from each moment of consciousness to the next
    - (c) the body
    - (d) the result of kamma only
6. Finish the sentence: “Generosity today or anger today conditions …”
7. Which of these is a *paramattha dhamma* (absolute reality) and not a concept?
    - (a) a tree
    - (b) hardness
    - (c) a house
    - (d) a person
8. What does seeing see, and what does it not see?
9. What is the condition for right mindfulness, according to the essay?
    - (a) sitting very still
    - (b) intellectual understanding of what nāma and rūpa are
    - (c) following what the hands and feet are doing
    - (d) wanting it strongly
10. True or false: the essay says that following what one’s hands and feet are doing all day is the development of insight.
11. In the example of the husband taking the author’s hand, what appears through the body-sense, and what does the essay say about the attachment?
12. How does the essay answer the question whether developing insight is selfish?
13. The appendix describes *nibbāna* (the end of all troubles) with four words. Which?
    - (a) the deathless, the cool, the incomparable, the peaceful
    - (b) the high, the far, the bright, the wide
    - (c) earth, water, fire and wind
    - (d) seeing, hearing, smelling and tasting

The Abhidhamma on one page

Everything in the twelve lessons, in the order it was met.

Number	What	Lesson
3	baskets of the *Tipiṭaka* (the Three Baskets): *Vinaya* (discipline), *Sutta* (discourses), *Abhidhamma* (the higher teaching)	Introduction
7	books of the *Abhidhamma Piṭaka* (the Basket of the Higher Teaching)	Introduction
2	kinds of reality: *nāma* (mind), which experiences, and *rūpa* (matter), which does not	2
4	*paramattha dhamma* (absolute realities): *citta* (consciousness), *cetasika* (mental factors), *rūpa* (matter), *nibbāna* (the end of all troubles)	2
1	unconditioned reality: *nibbāna* (the end of all troubles)	2
89	kinds of *citta* (consciousness): 21 *kusala* (good), 12 *akusala* (bad), 36 *vipāka* (result), 20 *kiriya* (functional)	3
3	roots of bad moments: *lobha* (attachment), *dosa* (anger), *moha* (ignorance); "Greed, hate, and delusion"	3, 11
4	spheres of *citta* (consciousness): sense sphere 54, form sphere 15, formless sphere 12, beyond the world 8	3
5	feelings: pleasant, unpleasant and indifferent mental feeling; pleasant and unpleasant bodily feeling	3
52	*cetasika* (mental factors): 7 universals, 6 particulars, 14 bad, 19 beautiful, 3 abstinences, 2 illimitables, 1 wisdom	4
7	universal *cetasika* (mental factors): contact, feeling, memory, intention, concentration, psychic life, attention	4
28	kinds of *rūpa* (matter): 12 gross and 16 subtle	5
4	*mahābhūta* (great elements): earth (solidity), water (cohesion), fire (temperature), wind (motion)	5
8	kinds of *rūpa* (matter) in the smallest group, the *suddhaṭṭhaka kalāpa* (pure eightfold group)	5
5	*khandha* (aggregates): matter, feeling, perception, mental formations, consciousness	5
10	*akusala kamma* (bad deeds): three of body, four of speech, three of mind	6
10	*puñña kiriya vatthu* (bases of meritorious action)	6
1	mental factor that is *kamma* (deed): *cetanā* (intention)	6
31	planes of existence: 4 woeful, 1 human, 6 *deva* (heavenly), 20 *Brahmā* (highest heavenly)	7

Number	What	Lesson
2	moments at the join of two lives: *cuti-citta* (death consciousness) and *paṭisandhi-citta* (rebirth consciousness)	7
10	*saṃyojana* (fetters)	8
4	stages of enlightenment: *sotāpanna* (stream-enterer), *sakadāgāmī* (once-returner), *anāgāmī* (never-returner), *arahant* (fully enlightened)	8
12	links of *paṭicca samuppāda* (dependent origination), beginning with *avijjā* (ignorance)	9
4	Noble Truths: *dukkha* (suffering), its origin, its ending, the path	9
8	factors of the *ariya aṭṭhaṅgika magga* (the Noble Eightfold Path), 5 at every moment of true wisdom, all 8 at enlightenment	9
3	marks of all conditioned things: *anicca* (impermanent), *dukkha* (unsatisfactory), *anattā* (non-self)	9
6	doors through which realities appear: eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, mind	2, 12
0	persons in any of it	10, 11

Going on from here. The preface to the book says: “We should apply ourselves to the study of all parts of the Buddha’s teaching contained in the Pali Canon-to the Vinaya (the books of discipline for the Sangha), to the Suttas (the books of discourses) and to the Abhidhamma. Our own clarification of the teachings through reading, wise consideration and contemplation will be of much benefit to us and to all others who come into contact with us.” The book’s own reading list begins with *Abhidhamma in Daily Life* by Nina van Gorkom, which takes each of these lists further and can be read free of charge on abhidhamma.org. After that comes the *Abhidhammattha Saṅgaha* (the Compendium of Abhidhamma), the short manual by the Elder Anuruddha that every student of the Abhidhamma in Burma, Sri Lanka and Thailand has learnt for a thousand years, and which gives all the lists in this course in full.

Word list

Every Pali word in this course, with the English used for it. The words are in the order of the English alphabet, ignoring the marks on the letters.

Pali	English
Abhidhamma	the higher teaching
Abhidhamma Piṭaka	the Basket of the Higher Teaching
Abhidhammattha Saṅgaha	the Compendium of Abhidhamma
adosa	non-hate
ahirika	shamelessness
akusala	bad
akusala cetasika	bad mental factors
akusala citta	bad consciousness
akusala kamma	bad deeds
anāgāmī	never-returner
anattā	non-self
anicca	impermanent
anottappa	fearlessness of wrong
apāya	woeful planes
āpo dhātu	the element of water
appamaññā	illimitables
arahant	fully enlightened disciple
ariya aṭṭhaṅgika magga	the Noble Eightfold Path
asura	titan
aṭṭhakathā	commentaries
Atthasālinī	The Expositor
āvajjana	adverting
avijjā	ignorance
bhava	becoming
bhavaṅga	life-continuum
bhavaṅga citta	life-continuum consciousness
bhūmi	sphere
Brahmā	highest heavenly being

Pali	English
cakkhu-viññāṇa	seeing
cetanā	intention
cetasika	mental factors
citta	consciousness
Cūḷahatthipadopama Sutta	the Shorter Discourse on the Simile of the Elephant's Footprint
cuti-citta	death consciousness
deva	heavenly being
Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta	the Discourse on Setting the Wheel of the Teaching in Motion
Dhātuvibhaṅga Sutta	the Discourse on the Analysis of the Elements
dosa	anger
dukkha	suffering
dvāra	doors
ekaggatā	concentration
issā	envy
jarā-maraṇa	decay and death
jāti	birth
javana	running
jhāna	deep calm of mind
kamma	deed
kammaññatā	adaptability
karuṇā	compassion
Kathāvatthu	Points of Controversy
khandha	aggregates
kiriya	functional
kiriya citta	functional consciousness
kukkucca	worry
kusala	good
kusala citta	good consciousness
kusala kamma	a good deed
lahutā	lightness
lobha	attachment

Pali	English
lokuttara citta	consciousness beyond the world
macchariya	stinginess
magga	the path
magga citta	path consciousness
mahābhūta	great elements
Mahāvaṃsa	the Great Chronicle of Ceylon
māna	conceit
manussa	the human plane
mātikā	a table of headings
mettā	loving-kindness
moha	ignorance
muditā	sympathetic joy
mudutā	pliancy
nāma	mind
nāma-rūpa	mind and matter
nibbāna	the end of all troubles
nimmita	created
nirodha	its ending
pāguññatā	proficiency
pakiṇṇaka	particulars
paññā	wisdom
paññatti	concept
paramattha dhamma	absolute realities
paramattha sacca	ultimate truth
passaddhi	composure
paṭhavī dhātu	the element of earth
paṭicca samuppāda	dependent origination
paṭisandhi-citta	rebirth consciousness
Paṭṭhāna	the book of conditions
peta	unhappy ghost
phala citta	fruition consciousness

Pali	English
phassa	contact
puñña kiriya vatthu	bases of meritorious action
rūpa	matter
rūpa-khandha	the group of matter
sakadāgāmī	once-returner
Sakka	the king of the heavenly beings
sakkāya diṭṭhi	personality belief
saḷāyatana	the six-fold bases, the five senses and thinking
sammā ājīva	right livelihood
sammā kammanta	right action
sammā vācā	right speech
sammuti sacca	conventional truth
sampaṭicchana	receiving
saṃsāra	the round of births
samudaya	its origin
saṃyojana	fetters
Saṃyutta Nikāya	the Grouped Discourses
Saṅgha	the order
saṅgīti	a council
saṅkhāra	karmic activities, deeds
saṅkhāra-khandha	the group of mental formations
saññā	memory
saññā-khandha	the group of perception, or memory
santīraṇa	investigating
sati	mindfulness
sobhana cetasika	beautiful mental factors
sotāpanna	stream-enterer
suddhaṭṭhaka kalāpa	pure eightfold group
Suddhāvāsa	the Pure Abodes
Sutta	discourse
Sutta Piṭaka	the Basket of Discourses

Pali	English
tadārammaṇa	registering
taṇhā	craving
Tāvatiṃsa	the heaven of the Thirty-three
tejo dhātu	the element of fire
tilakkhaṇa	the three characteristics
Tipiṭaka	the Three Baskets
Tusita	the heaven of the contented
Udāna	the Inspired Utterances
uddhacca	restlessness
ujukatā	rectitude, straightness
upādāna	grasping
vāyo dhātu	the element of wind
vedanā	feeling
vedanā-khandha	the group of feeling
Vinaya	discipline
Vinaya Piṭaka	the Basket of Discipline
viññāṇa	consciousness
viññāṇa-khandha	the group of consciousness
vipāka	result
vipāka citta	result consciousness
vipassanā	insight
virati	abstinences
viriya	effort
Visuddhimagga	the Path of Purity
vitakka	applied thought
vīthi	a process
votthapana	determining

Hard words

Every hard English word in this book has a small number after it the first time it is met in a chapter, and its meaning is given at the end of that chapter. Here are all of them together, in alphabetical order.

- **absolute**: complete and real in itself; not depending on names or ideas
- **abstain**: to hold back from doing something, such as lying
- **abuse**: to treat or speak to someone cruelly and rudely
- **accumulate**: to gather up bit by bit, so that there is more and more of it
- **adaptability**: being able to fit to what is needed
- **adverting**: turning towards something
- **aggregate**: a group or heap of things taken together
- **alms**: food given to monks
- **alteration**: a change
- **amity**: friendliness
- **analyse**: to take something apart carefully to see what it is made of
- **arise**: to come up; to begin; to happen
- **ascetic**: a person who gives up home and comfort to live simply and seek the truth; or that hard way of living
- **atrocious**: very cruel and terrible
- **attachment**: wanting something and holding on to it; liking that will not let go
- **aversion**: not liking something and wanting it to go away; anger, even a little
- **awareness**: noticing what is really there right now; another word for mindfulness
- **being**: any living creature: a person, an animal, a heavenly being
- **bodysense**: the sense of touch, all over the body
- **bough**: a big branch of a tree
- **canon**: the set of writings accepted as the true teaching
- **cessation**: stopping; coming to an end
- **characteristic**: the mark by which something is known; what is special about it
- **chariot**: a cart with two wheels pulled by horses, used in old times for war and travel
- **chronicle**: a history written down in order of time
- **classification**: sorting things into kinds
- **clinging**: holding on tightly; not wanting to let go
- **cohesion**: holding together; the sticking-together of the parts
- **commentary**: an old explanation of a text, written to make it clear
- **compassion**: wanting to help someone who is suffering
- **composure**: calmness
- **conceit**: thinking oneself better than others, or worse, or just as good; pride that compares
- **concentration**: keeping the mind on one thing

- **concept**: an idea put together by thinking, such as ‘tree’ or ‘person’; it cannot be seen or touched by itself
- **conception**: the very start of a new life inside the mother
- **condition**: something that has to be there before another thing can happen
- **conditioned**: made to happen by other things; it could not come up on its own
- **confidence**: trust in what is true and good; sureness
- **consciousness**: a moment of mind that knows something, such as seeing or hearing
- **considerate**: thinking of other people’s feelings
- **constituent**: a part that something is made of
- **controversy**: an argument between people who disagree
- **conventional**: the ordinary everyday way of talking, as when a pile of parts is called a chariot
- **council**: a big meeting of the elder monks to settle something
- **covetousness**: wanting what belongs to someone else
- **craving**: strong wanting; a thirst for something
- **deathless**: without death; never dying
- **deed**: something done; an act, good or bad
- **defilement**: something that makes the mind dirty: wanting, anger, not knowing and the rest
- **delusion**: being fooled; not seeing things as they are
- **derived**: coming from something else and depending on it
- **despair**: losing all hope
- **detachment**: not holding on; letting go
- **determination**: making up one’s mind firmly and keeping to it
- **disciple**: a pupil; someone who follows a teacher
- **discourse**: a talk or sermon; here, one of the Buddha’s talks written down
- **disinterestedness**: not wanting anything for oneself
- **ego**: the self; the idea of ‘I’
- **element**: one of the basic parts that everything is made of
- **eliminate**: to get rid of
- **endure**: to bear something hard without giving up
- **enlightenment**: the moment when the truth is seen fully and for good, and the dirt of the mind is cut away
- **enumerate**: to count up and list one by one
- **envy**: being unhappy because someone else has something good
- **equanimity**: an even, calm mind that is not shaken by good luck or bad
- **eradicate**: to root out completely, so that it can never come back
- **ere**: before
- **estranged**: cut off from; made a stranger to
- **experience**: to know, see, hear or feel something; or the knowing itself
- **expire**: to run out; to come to an end

- **fall away**: to end; to stop; to be gone
- **famine**: a time when there is no food
- **fear of unwholesomeness**: being afraid of the harm that doing wrong brings
- **fetter**: a chain for the feet; here, what keeps a being tied to the round of birth and death
- **figment**: something made up; imagined
- **frivolous**: silly and useless
- **fruition**: bearing fruit; here, the moment that comes right after the path moment
- **function**: the job that something does
- **functional**: doing a job without being a cause or a result
- **generosity**: giving freely and gladly
- **grasping**: holding on tightly; clinging
- **grief**: deep sadness, as when someone dies
- **gross**: here, coarse and easy to notice; not 'disgusting'
- **habitual**: done out of habit, again and again
- **harmonious**: peaceful and well ordered, like music that fits together
- **hinder**: to get in the way of; to hold back
- **hither**: here; to this place
- **ignorance**: not knowing; not understanding what is really there
- **ill will**: wishing someone harm
- **illimitable**: without limit; boundless
- **immoral**: bad conduct; wrong
- **impermanent**: not lasting; passing away
- **inclination**: a leaning towards something; what one tends to do
- **indifferent**: neither pleasant nor unpleasant; in the middle
- **indulge**: to give in to something one enjoys, too much
- **inoperative**: not working as a cause; bringing no result
- **insight**: seeing into something; here, seeing clearly for oneself that there is only mind and matter
- **intact**: whole; not damaged or changed
- **intellectual**: to do with thinking and understanding by the mind, not with seeing for oneself
- **intention**: what the mind means to do; the mind's choosing
- **intimation**: a sign that makes a meaning known, as a nod or a word does
- **justification**: a reason given to make something seem right
- **lamentation**: crying out in sorrow
- **liable**: likely
- **liberation**: being set free
- **life-continuum**: the stream of mind that keeps life going when nothing is being seen, heard or thought, as in deep sleep
- **lifespan**: the length of a life

- **livelihood**: the way a person earns a living
- **loving-kindness**: wishing others well; friendliness to everyone
- **material**: made of matter; the stuff that does not know anything
- **matter**: the kind of reality that does not know or feel anything, such as hardness, colour or sound
- **meditation**: developing the mind; people use this word in many different ways
- **mental**: to do with the mind
- **mental factor**: something that goes along with each moment of mind and does its own small job, such as feeling or remembering
- **merit**: goodness earned by a good deed, which brings a good result later
- **mindfulness**: noticing what is really there right now, without forgetting
- **misconduct**: bad behaviour
- **misrepresent**: to describe someone wrongly; to give a false picture of them
- **momentary**: lasting only a moment
- **monk**: a man who has left home to follow the Buddha's rule of life
- **moral shame**: being ashamed to do wrong
- **morality**: good conduct; not killing, not stealing, not lying and the rest
- **nay**: no
- **non-self**: not a self; not a person; not anyone's
- **novice**: a boy or young man who has begun training to be a monk
- **nun**: a woman who has left home to follow the Buddha's rule of life
- **nutriment**: food; what feeds the body and keeps it going
- **object**: the thing that a moment of mind knows: a colour, a sound, a thought
- **origin**: where something comes from; its beginning
- **perception**: marking something in the mind so that it can be known again; remembering
- **perspective**: a way of seeing things; a view
- **phenomena**: things that happen or appear; here, the realities of mind and matter
- **philosophical**: to do with deep thinking about what is true
- **plane**: a world or level where beings live: the human world, the heavens, the animal world and so on
- **pliancy**: being soft and bendable, not stiff
- **process**: a row of moments that follow one another in order
- **proficiency**: skill; being good at doing something
- **prompted**: prompted: after some urging; unprompted: of one's own accord
- **psychic life**: the mental factor that keeps a moment of mind alive for its short time
- **purify**: to make clean; cleanness
- **qualification**: a paper that shows what one has learnt or can do
- **rapidity**: great speed
- **reality**: something that is really there, not only a name or an idea
- **realm**: a kingdom; here, one of the worlds that beings can be born in

- **rebirth**: being born again in a new life after this one ends
- **recite**: to say a text aloud from memory
- **rectitude**: straightness; being honest and right
- **registering**: taking note of
- **reign**: the time during which a king rules
- **rejoice**: to be glad
- **restlessness**: not being able to be still; a mind that jumps about
- **restraint**: holding oneself back from doing wrong
- **result**: what comes later from a deed done before, as fruit comes from a seed
- **resultant**: coming as a result
- **schismatic**: a group that has split off from the main group
- **scripture**: holy writings
- **sensual**: to do with the pleasures of the senses: nice sights, sounds, tastes and so on
- **sentient**: able to feel and know; alive and aware
- **shrewd**: quick and clever
- **sincere**: truly meant; honest
- **skilful**: done well, with skill; here, good for the mind (unskilful: bad for the mind)
- **slander**: saying untrue, unkind things about someone to other people
- **sloth**: laziness and dullness of mind
- **solidity**: hardness or softness; being solid
- **sphere**: an area or level; here, a level of mind
- **stag**: a male deer
- **stinginess**: not wanting to give or share; meanness
- **strife**: fighting and quarrelling
- **subtle**: fine, faint and hard to notice
- **succeeded by**: followed by; coming next
- **suffering**: pain and trouble; anything that cannot give lasting happiness
- **summation**: a summing up; a short account of the whole
- **superficial**: only on the surface; shallow
- **sympathetic joy**: being glad when someone else is happy or does well
- **tendency**: a leaning towards doing something; a habit of the mind
- **thera**: an elder monk
- **thicket**: a thick group of bushes
- **thou**: old words for ‘you’ and ‘have’
- **titan**: a kind of being that loves fighting
- **torment**: to cause great pain to
- **torpor**: heaviness and sleepiness of mind
- **tranquillity**: calm; stillness of mind

- **treatise**: a long, careful piece of writing on one subject
- **ultimate**: the deepest and most real; what is really there when all the names are taken away
- **unconditioned**: not made by anything; not depending on causes
- **universal**: found in every one; here, mental factors that come with every moment of mind
- **unsatisfactory**: never quite good enough; not able to give lasting happiness
- **unselfish**: thinking of others, not of oneself
- **unwholesome**: bad for the mind: wanting, anger, not knowing
- **upright**: honest and good
- **vague**: not clear; hazy
- **wholesome**: good and healthy for the mind: giving, kindness, patience, understanding
- **wit**: cleverness; a quick mind
- **woe**: sorrow and trouble
- **woeful**: full of sorrow; very unhappy
- **womb**: the place inside a mother where a baby grows
- **wrong view**: a wrong idea about what is real, such as the idea that there is a lasting self

Where it comes from

This course follows *An Introduction to the Abhidhamma*, printed for free distribution by the Dhamma Study Group, Bangkok, at New Year 1980, and dedicated to Sister Sudhammā (Pauline Ofner, 1927 to 1979). The book has two essays and an appendix. The first essay, *Abhidhamma Notes* by Jill Jordan and Richard Giles, was written as an introduction to the Abhidhamma for a comparative religion class in Adelaide, South Australia; Lessons 1 to 10 keep to its order, its explanations and, as far as a course for young readers allows, its words. The second essay, *Abhidhamma and Practice* by Nina van Gorkom, was written for a Dhamma publication in Holland; Lessons 11 and 12 follow it. The appendix, *The Paramattha Dhammas*, lists all 89 (or 121) kinds of consciousness, the 52 mental factors and the 28 kinds of matter, and the tables in Lessons 3, 4 and 5 are taken from it. Where this course quotes a sentence in quotation marks, the words are those of the book or of the translation it uses.

The book itself draws on these ancient texts, and the course has gone to them for the stories:

- The *Atthasālinī* (The Expositor), Buddhaghosa's commentary on the *Dhammasaṅgaṇī*, the first book of the Abhidhamma, for the teaching of the Abhidhamma in *Tāvatiṃsa* (the heaven of the Thirty-three), the created Buddha, Sāriputta and his five hundred pupils, and the recital of the Abhidhamma at the First Council.
- The *Dhammapada* commentary, for the descent from heaven at Saṅkassa.
- The *Mahāvaṃsa* (the Great Chronicle of Ceylon), chapters 14 and 33, in the translation of Wilhelm Geiger, for the Elder Mahinda's meeting with King Devānampiyatissa and for the writing down of the *Tipiṭaka* (the Three Baskets) in Sri Lanka. The *Samantapāsādikā*, the commentary on the *Vinaya* (discipline), for the three councils.
- The *Visuddhimagga* (the Path of Purity) by Buddhaghosa, for the chariot and for the closing verse, both quoted in the book.
- The *Saṃyutta Nikāya* (the Grouped Discourses): the discourse on the heap of sticks (ii, 178) and King Pasenadi's question about the three things that make for trouble (the Kindred Sayings, I, III, iii, 3), both quoted in the book; the verses of the nun Vajirā (the *Vajirā Sutta*), the discourse on the dirt on the fingernail and the first sermon, the *Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta*, in the translation of Bhikkhu Sujato.
- The *Udāna* (the Inspired Utterances), for the Buddha's words to Bāhiya, in the translation of Bhikkhu Sujato.
- The *Majjhima Nikāya* (the Middle Length Discourses), the *Dhātuvibhaṅga Sutta*, for the elements in the body.
- The *Dhammapada*, verse 100, quoted at the front of the book.
- The *Abhidhammattha Saṅgaha* (the Compendium of Abhidhamma) by the Elder Anuruddha, for the Pali names of the ten bad deeds, the ten bases of merit, the planes, the fetters and the moments of a sense-door process, where the book gives only the English or does not go into them.

Where the ancient texts and modern scholars differ, this course follows the ancient texts. In particular, it follows the *Atthasālinī* (The Expositor) in holding that the Abhidhamma is the Buddha's own teaching, recited at the First Council, and that the *Kathāvatthu* (Points of Controversy) was set out by the Elder Moggaliputta Tissa at the Third Council on an outline the Buddha had laid down.

The whole of the Abhidhamma, with many more books about it, can be read free of charge on abhidhamma.org.

Answers

Quiz 1 (lessons 1 and 2)

1. (b) "higher" and "reality" or "truth". The book says: "'abhi' meaning 'higher' or 'greater' and 'dhamma' which means 'reality' or 'truth'". So *Abhidhamma* means "the higher truth" or "the higher teaching".
2. (b) seven; the *Paṭṭhāna*. There are seven books. The *Paṭṭhāna* (the book of conditions) is "the largest and the most important Abhidhamma work".
3. In *Tāvatiṃsa* (the heaven of the Thirty-three), to his mother and the *devas* (heavenly beings), for the three months of the rainy season in the seventh year after his enlightenment.
4. Each day, when the Buddha came down to the lake Anotatta, he told Sāriputta the method of what had been taught in heaven that day. Sāriputta taught it to his five hundred pupils, who memorised and mastered it.
5. (b) a stag, which was a *deva* (heavenly being) in disguise. The king was hunting on the Missaka mountain. A *deva* (heavenly being) appeared "in the form of an elk-stag browsing in the thicket", and "the stag in his flight drew near to the thera".
6. To find out whether the king was quick enough to follow the teaching. When the king answered well, "Thou hast a shrewd wit, O ruler of men!" Only when he knew the king was keen-witted did he preach.
7. False. For a long time nothing was written down; the whole canon was committed to memory by groups of monks. It was written on palm leaves in Sri Lanka more than four hundred years after the Buddha, "in order that the true doctrine might endure".
8. (b) the sound of the bell. Sound is an object of experience, and "does not experience anything (this being the characteristic of rupa)". Hearing, liking and remembering all experience something, so they are *nāma* (mind).
9. *Citta* (consciousness), *cetasika* (mental factors), *rūpa* (matter) and *nibbāna* (the end of all troubles). *Nibbāna* is the one unconditioned reality: "there are no causes which make it arise".
10. False. The book says: "Seeing is not hearing. They do not occur together, they occur at different moments, although we are under the impression that they do occur together."
11. It "is not matter, it is not a place where one goes, it has no form or shape or solidity, it is not something that one unites with". It does not begin or end, and it cannot be understood intellectually.

Quiz 2 (lessons 3 and 4)

1. (b) 89 kinds in 4 classes. "Citta (consciousness) is of 89 different types. Cittas are divided into four categories": *kusala* (good) 21, *akusala* (bad) 12, *vipāka* (result) 36 and *kiriya* (functional) 20.
2. 1. *akusala citta* (bad consciousness), 12; 2. *kiriya citta* (functional consciousness), 20; 3. *kusala citta* (good consciousness), 21; 4. *vipāka citta* (result consciousness), 36. 12 bad, 20 functional, 21 good, 36 result. Together they make 89.
3. (a) being bored. The book's examples are "when we get angry, when we are bored, when we are depressed, when we are absorbed in beautiful things, when we kill or steal or lie to people or when we are restless". Bowing and holding back from a lie are *kusala* (good). Seeing a colour is *vipāka* (result).

4. *Vipāka* (result). “When we see, hear, taste, smell or touch pleasant or unpleasant objects it is result”, the result of a deed in the past. The seeing itself is neither good nor bad.
5. (c) unpleasant feeling. The two kinds rooted in aversion “are accompanied by unpleasant feeling”. Attachment can come with pleasant or indifferent feeling; ignorance with indifferent feeling.
6. Consciousness that is neither cause nor result: it has “no effect in terms of cause and result”. It arises in the sense-door process, in the thought processes of enlightened beings and in nine of the meditative states.
7. (b) *māna* (conceit). “The characteristic of conceit is haughtiness and self-praise is its function.”
8. Contact, feeling, perception (or memory), intention, concentration, psychic life and attention: *phassa*, *vedanā*, *saññā*, *cetanā*, *ekaggatā*, *jīvitindriya*, *manasikāra*.
9. False. “Kindness and hate cannot occur together at the same moment, restlessness and balance of mind cannot occur together, compassion and conceit cannot occur together.”
10. (c) 52. “There are 52 different types of cetasikas”: 7 universals, 6 particulars, 14 bad, 19 beautiful, 3 abstinences, 2 illimitables and wisdom.
11. *Adosa* (non-hate), one of the nineteen beautiful mental factors, when it takes living beings as its object. It is not a person’s feeling; it is a conditioned mental factor that arises and falls away.

Quiz 3 (lessons 5 and 6)

1. (a) 28: 12 gross and 16 subtle. “There are 28 classes of rupa, 16 being classified as subtle and 12 as gross.”
2. Earth, or solidity; water, or cohesion; fire, or temperature; wind, or motion. In Pali: *paṭhavī*, *āpo*, *tejo*, *vāyo*.
3. False. “Hardness is a type of rupa (matter). It cannot know anything about anything.”
4. (b) the eye-sense. The derived rupas are “the physical sense-organs of eye-sense, ear-sense, taste-sense, etc., and the sense-objects of colour, sound, smell and flavour”, and others such as heart-base, nutritive essence and space. Seeing, feeling and doubt are *nāma* (mind).
5. A group of eight: the four great elements, colour, smell, flavour and nutritive essence. Matter never arises as a single kind.
6. (b) the results of deeds done in the past. “Whenever we see, hear, taste, smell or touch an object, that experience … is resultant-consciousness (vipaka-citta). It is the result of a deed performed at some time in the past.”
7. 1. *cetanā* (intention) arises with a moment of consciousness, as it does with every moment; 2. the intention grows strong enough to move the body or the speech; 3. one of the ten good or bad deeds is done: this is *kamma* (deed); 4. at some time in the future, a pleasant or unpleasant result arises as seeing, hearing, smelling, tasting or touching. Intention is universal; when it is strong enough to motivate one of the ten kinds of action it is called *kamma* (deed), “because it is strong enough to produce a result at some time in the future”.
8. “The justification for killing is just thinking, but the actual moment of killing is always immoral and never to anybody’s benefit.” The ten bad deeds, “no matter what the justification that we make for them, are always immoral actions”.

9. (a) rejoicing in others' merit. The ten are generosity, restraint, mental development, respect, service, sharing of merit, rejoicing in others' merit, listening to Dhamma, teaching Dhamma and straightening one's views.
10. The mental factor *cetanā* (intention). Intention arises with every moment, but "when intention motivates one of the ten types of moral or immoral actions through body, speech or mind then it is called kamma because it is strong enough to produce a result at some time in the future".
11. False. "Sharing of merit is not practised at all in western countries today. It is something difficult for us to understand since we don't admit the existence of other realms of beings."
12. "… be kind, respectful, generous, honest and upright in character. The Buddha taught quite clearly that it is deeds in the past that determine our life situation right now."

Quiz 4 (lessons 7 and 8)

1. (c) 31. "The Buddha enumerated 31 planes of existence": 4 woeful planes, the human plane, 6 planes of *devas* (heavenly beings) and 20 planes of *Brahmās* (the highest heavenly beings).
2. The hell realms, the realm of *asuras* (titans), the realm of *petas* (unhappy ghosts) and the animal realm. Only the animal realm can be seen by human beings.
3. (b) they are all temporary. "Existence in all of these planes has one thing in common, it is temporary, it does not last." So "heaven is not the end of it all".
4. The sticks. If he laid one for each mother, "the straw, boughs, twigs and leaves in this India would come to an end and be used up" before the mothers were counted. There is no beginning to the round of births.
5. 1. a past deed, or a habit, becomes the object of the last thought process; 2. the mind reacts to it with *kusala* (good) or *akusala* (bad); 3. *cuti-citta* (death consciousness), the last moment of this life; 4. *paṭisandhi-citta* (rebirth consciousness), the first moment of the next life. The last process takes a deed or habit as object; the reaction decides the plane; then death consciousness, then at once rebirth consciousness. There is no gap.
6. False. "Whatever persons surround us or help us they cannot determine our last thought process. It depends upon deeds in the past what happens to us at death."
7. (b) wrong view, doubt and adherence to rule and ritual. "At the first stage, a being has eliminated the first three fetters": wrong view, doubt and adherence to rule and ritual.
8. He "has entered the stream to final enlightenment". "There are no more conditions to be born in a lower plane than that of a human being."
9. (b) sense desire and aversion. "A never-returner (anagami) eliminates two further fetters, these being sense-desire and aversion. He has no more desire for sense-objects and no more dislike for unpleasant things."
10. Attachment to existence in the form realms, attachment to existence in the formless realm, conceit, restlessness and ignorance.
11. "When an arahant dies, that is all. No more experience. No more rebirth. This is called by the Buddha the only true peace." The last moment is not followed by another rebirth consciousness.
12. False. The belief "that there is a method or a technique or something which one performs that will lead one to enlightenment" is itself one of the three fetters cut at the first stage.

Quiz 5 (lessons 9 and 10)

1. (c) ignorance. “We can see then that at the root of it all is ignorance. That is defined as ignorance of the Four Noble Truths.”
2. 1. *phassa* (contact); 2. *vedanā* (feeling); 3. *taṇhā* (craving); 4. *upādāna* (grasping). Dependent on contact arises feeling; dependent on feeling arises craving; dependent on craving arises grasping.
3. Life is unsatisfactory, *dukkha* (suffering); suffering arises because of craving; there is an ending of suffering, *nibbāna* (the end of all troubles); the way to that ending is the Noble Eightfold Path.
4. (b) eight mental factors that arise together in a moment of wisdom. “In the Abhidhamma it is made clear that the Eightfold Path is in fact only momentary phenomena like everything else … at the moment that a wholesome moment of wisdom … arises then it is accompanied by the Eightfold Path factors as mental factors (cetasikas).”
5. “Five of these factors accompany every moment of true wisdom. The whole eight occur together only at the moments of enlightenment.”
6. *Dukkha* (unsatisfactory: there is no lasting satisfaction in them), *anicca* (impermanent: they do not last even for a moment) and *anattā* (non-self: they are all empty of self).
7. (b) body-sense consciousness experiencing hardness, seeing, and memory, each at a different moment. “It is, in fact, a type of (body-sense) consciousness which experiences hardness through the body, seeing which sees and memory which remembers what we are doing … So in reality no ‘person’ exists who is ‘sitting’ on a ‘chair’.”
8. False. “Hardness is not a seat. ‘Seat’ or ‘chair’ are conventional labels we give to other sets of experience through different senses.”
9. “When people insult us, it is just sound appearing through the ear.” The hearing is *vipāka* (result); the sound is *rūpa* (matter); the hurt is *dosa* (anger) arising in a later moment.
10. ”… no person in them. This knowledge as it develops, ultimately brings us release from this unsatisfactory wheel of existence.”
11. (b) the world, its origin, its ceasing and the means to its cessation. “As long as a man is vague about the world, / About its origin, about its ceasing, / About the means that lead to its cessation, / So long he cannot recognise the truths.”

Quiz 6 (lessons 11 and 12)

1. (b) three: greed, hate and delusion. “Three things, sire, happen of that nature. What are the three? Greed, hate, and delusion:—these three make for trouble, for suffering, for distress.”
2. Not “we”: “We cannot eradicate the defilements of others, ‘we’ cannot even eradicate our own defilements. But when right understanding has been developed, it is right understanding which can gradually eradicate defilements. But this may take many lives.”
3. False. “Love is real, but it falls away immediately, and it does not belong to a self who could be master of it.”
4. That there is no master of them: “We can have the intention to be kind, but we cannot force ourselves to kindness. When things are not the way we want them to be we may become angry, in spite of ourselves, as we say. This shows us that phenomena are anatta, not self.”

5. (b) an accumulation of experiences handed on from each moment of consciousness to the next. “There is nothing lasting in a man, not even what we call his character.” But “we can still speak of an ‘accumulation’ of experiences in each moment of consciousness, and we can call this character.”
6. ”… generosity or anger in the future. A moment of right understanding now conditions right understanding in the future, and thus it is possible to develop wisdom.”
7. (b) hardness. “Person, animal, tree or house are not paramattha dhammas, they are concepts.” Hardness is a *rūpa* (matter) that can be directly experienced through the body-sense.
8. “Seeing sees and it does not think … There is seeing, and seeing sees visible object. Seeing does not see a man or a tree.” Shape and form, and persons, are known by thinking, in later moments.
9. (b) intellectual understanding of what nāma and rūpa are. “The condition for right mindfulness is intellectual understanding of what nama and rupa are: realities which appear through the six doorways.” Mindfulness “can arise when there are the appropriate conditions”, not because of our will.
10. False. “When one, for example, follows what one’s hands and feet are doing in a day one does not learn anything about nama and rupa, about what is real, about impermanence.”
11. “Heat or cold, hardness or softness can appear through the body-sense”, “not a person, not my husband”. Of the attachment: “There is attachment and this is real, we do not have to try to suppress it.”
12. “Through the development of insight we will become more patient, we will have more loving-kindness and compassion. Thus, the development of insight is to the benefit of other people as well.”
13. (a) the deathless, the cool, the incomparable, the peaceful. “Nibbana is described as the ‘deathless’, the ‘cool’, the ‘incomparable’, the ‘peaceful’. It is the end of craving, the goal of the Buddha’s teachings.”